

SAMĀDHI WATER

REPENTANCE COMPANION

An explained English guide to Scroll One

Concepts • section guide • figures • pronunciation • glossary

Prepared by Daniel Franjkovic

daniel.franjkovic@outlook.com.au

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Samādhi Water Repentance Companion

An explained English guide to Scroll One

Prepared by
Daniel Franjkovic
daniel.franjkovic@outlook.com.au

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Further glossary
www.fgsitc.org/glossary/

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Detailed PDF bookmarks provide direct navigation to every major section.



Part I • Practice companion

What each part of Scroll One is doing and why

An explained companion to Scroll One

For other Buddhist terms, visit the Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center Glossary.

This companion explains the English text of the 2022 Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple edition. It does not reproduce or replace the liturgy. Keep the official Scroll One PDF beside this guide when reading or chanting.

How to use this guide

Read “The Buddhist world behind the words” first if the terms karma, Pure Land, emptiness or bodhisattva are new. Then use the page-by-page guide below while following the source.

Source-page references use the PDF page number. The smaller printed number inside the liturgy starts later and is different.

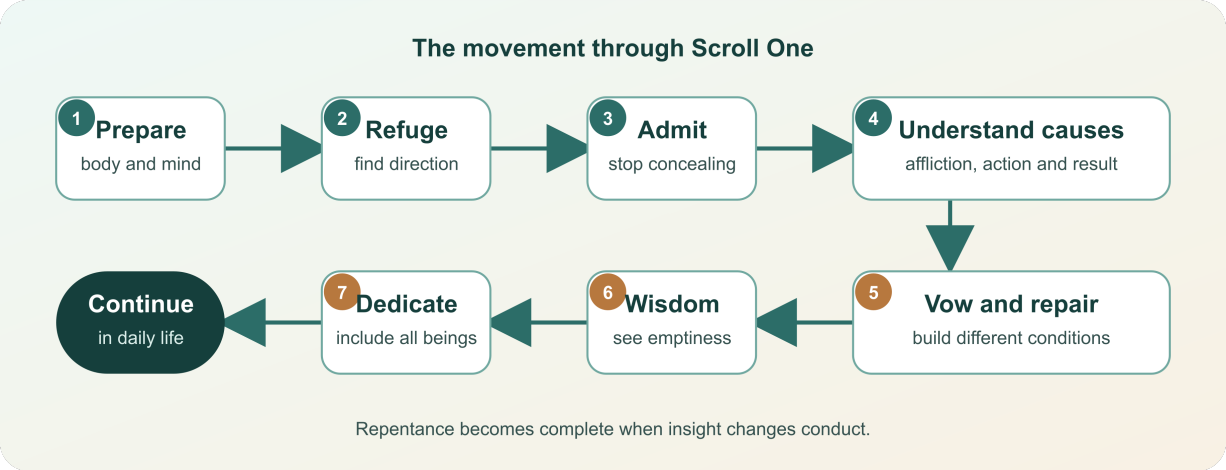
> In simple terms The practice asks: What has caused harm? Can I admit it without hiding? What conditions fed it? What will I do differently? How can the benefit of that change include others?

What the title means

- Kindness and compassion name the attitude towards oneself and all beings.
- Samādhi is a collected, steady mind that is not swept away by reactions.
- Water symbolises cleansing and refers to the spring in the traditional Wuda story.
- Repentance means acknowledging harm and reforming future conduct.

- Liturgy means a structured communal service of chant, movement, reflection and dedication.

The practice at a glance



The ritual is not simply a long confession. It moves from reverence and attention to honest acknowledgement, analysis of causes, vows, wisdom and dedication.

Guide to Scroll One

1. Imperial Preface for Water Repentance

Source pages 3 to 4

What is happening?

A Ming-period imperial preface explains the title and recommends the practice. It defines samādhi as a mind that does not indulge or chase sensation, then compares repentance with washing a body, garment or vessel.

Why is it here?

The preface gives the reader a moral frame before the chanting begins: actions have effects, the mind is central, and sincere reform can change the conditions that support suffering.

What does it mean?

“Samādhi water” is both story and metaphor. The water cleanses because it is joined with collected awareness, truthfulness and change. The point is not that ordinary water magically deletes the past.

Beginner notes

- National Master was an honorific for a highly respected monastic teacher associated with the imperial court.
- Karmic enmity means hostility carried and reinforced through intentional actions, traditionally across lives.
- Trichiliocosm is an ancient Buddhist expression for an immensely vast world-system.
- The preface is dated 24 July 1416, much later than the traditional Tang setting of Wuda's story.

2. Preface of the Water Repentance

Source pages 4 to 5

What is happening?

The liturgy tells its traditional origin narrative. Wuda Zhixuan cares for a sick monk when others avoid him. Later, after receiving an imperial throne and becoming proud, Wuda develops a human-faced tumour. The tumour speaks as a former enemy. Honoured Kanaka directs Wuda to wash it with water from a spring, ending the feud.

Why is it here?

The story makes invisible patterns visible. Pride weakens vigilance. Kindness creates a future refuge. Retaliation persists until its causes are understood and released.

What does it mean?

The tumour represents unresolved harm that cannot be escaped by status, learning or denial. Wuda's healing is not only the removal of pain. It is reconciliation with a being presented as his enemy across lives.

> Historical note The Wuda account is the liturgy's traditional explanation. Modern scholarship finds the exact authorship uncertain and notes that versions of the attribution were questioned in medieval China. The guide treats the story as a sacred origin narrative, not verified medical history.

Beginner notes

- Kāmalā disease is an old medical term associated with jaundice and severe illness.
- Honoured Kanaka is the mysterious awakened helper in the narrative. The text does not give a historically verifiable biography.
- The story assumes rebirth and karmic continuity. It should not be used to blame an ill person for unknown past conduct.

3. Prostrations and the True Incense Praise

Source page 7

What is happening?

The assembly bows, prostrates three times and praises the “true incense” of ethical discipline and concentration.

Why is it done?

The body enters the practice before the main confession begins. Prostration softens pride, while incense makes intention visible through fragrance rising and spreading.

What does it mean?

The real offering is not smoke alone. Ethical conduct and a steady mind are the fragrance the practitioner is asked to cultivate.

> Look for this in a temple Three prostrations often express complete homage to the Buddha, Dharma and Sangha. Follow the officiant's pace if attending a service.

4. Retelling the Wuda story

Source pages 8 to 10

What is happening?

A formal verse retells the origin story in elevated ritual language. It moves from pride and karmic enmity through the journey to Kanaka and the cleansing water.

Why is it done?

Repetition changes the story from background information into contemplation. Practitioners are invited to recognise their own pride, grudges and hidden patterns.

Beginner notes

- Ten unwholesome deeds are killing, stealing, sexual misconduct; false, divisive, harsh and careless speech; greed, ill will and wrong views.
- Five degenerations describe a troubled age marked by decline in lifespan, beings, afflictions, views and the age itself.
- Nine grades of lotuses are traditional levels of rebirth in Amitābha's Pure Land.

5. Samantabhadra visualisation

Source pages 10 to 12

What is happening?

The assembly invokes Samantabhadra, then imagines the bodhisattva approaching on a white elephant amid light, flowers, music and countless awakened beings.

Why is it done?

Samantabhadra represents great vows expressed as conduct. The visualisation turns the imagination towards a world shaped by wisdom, beauty and purposeful action.

What does it mean?

The scene should not be read like a newspaper report. It is sacred imagery that trains perception. Light represents wisdom; flowers represent virtue and impermanence; the elephant represents calm strength; its six tusks are commonly linked with the six perfections.

The six perfections are generosity, ethical discipline, patience, diligent effort, meditation and wisdom.

> Why this matters Repentance is incomplete if it only looks backward. Samantabhadra asks what vow and practice will replace the harmful pattern.

6. Refuge and universal offering

Source pages 12 to 15

What is happening?

The assembly prostrates to the Buddha, Dharma and Sangha, kneels with incense and flowers, and imagines the offering multiplying throughout all worlds.

Why is it done?

Taking refuge establishes the direction of the practice. The universal offering expands generosity beyond the limits of what is physically present.

What does it mean?

The language in which every offering contains all offerings reflects the Flower Adornment vision of interdependence. A small sincere act can participate in a much wider field of benefit.

Beginner notes

- Ten directions means everywhere: the four main directions, four intermediate directions, above and below.
- Dharma realm means the whole field of beings and phenomena.

- Bodhi mind is the resolve to awaken for the benefit of all beings.
- Non-arising means insight that phenomena do not appear from an independent permanent essence.

7. Prayer of entering repentance

Source pages 15 to 18

What is happening?

The assembly formally enters the repentance sanctuary. Practitioners purify body, speech and mind, take refuge, confess and ask the awakened assembly to witness their sincerity.

Why is it done?

Ritual boundaries help the mind stop treating the words as ordinary reading. Kneeling, joined palms, flowers and incense support concentrated honesty.

What does it mean?

“Purifying the three karmas” means bringing bodily conduct, speech and intention into alignment. “Four forms of birth” and “six realms” place the confession within the traditional scope of all sentient life.

The Seven Ancient Buddhas then situate the practice in a lineage of awakening extending beyond one historical age.

8. Opening confession and Buddha-name litany

Source pages 19 to 23

What is happening?

The assembly admits disbelief, arrogance, neglect of family, intoxicant use, killing, sexual craving and other harmful conduct. It then invokes Buddhas, bodhisattvas and sacred assemblies.

Why is it done?

Naming patterns weakens concealment. Reciting awakened names provides a contrasting field of qualities: wisdom, compassion, strength, vows and liberation.

What does it mean?

The passage uses “we” and covers more wrongdoing than any one reader may have committed. Communal repentance is deliberately comprehensive. A practitioner can acknowledge the pattern without making a false personal confession.

> Reading responsibly Do not mechanically claim an action you did not commit. Attend to the forms of harm that genuinely apply, the social conditions that allow harm and the commitment to prevent it.

Beginner notes

- Field of merit means a person or community in relation to whom wholesome action bears abundant benefit, like a well-tended field bearing crops.
- Pratyekabuddha means one who awakens without teaching a dispensation to the world.
- Four fruitions and four progressions are four stages of early Buddhist awakening, each viewed as path and result.
- Devas and nāgas are non-human beings in traditional Buddhist cosmology.

9. The three obstructions

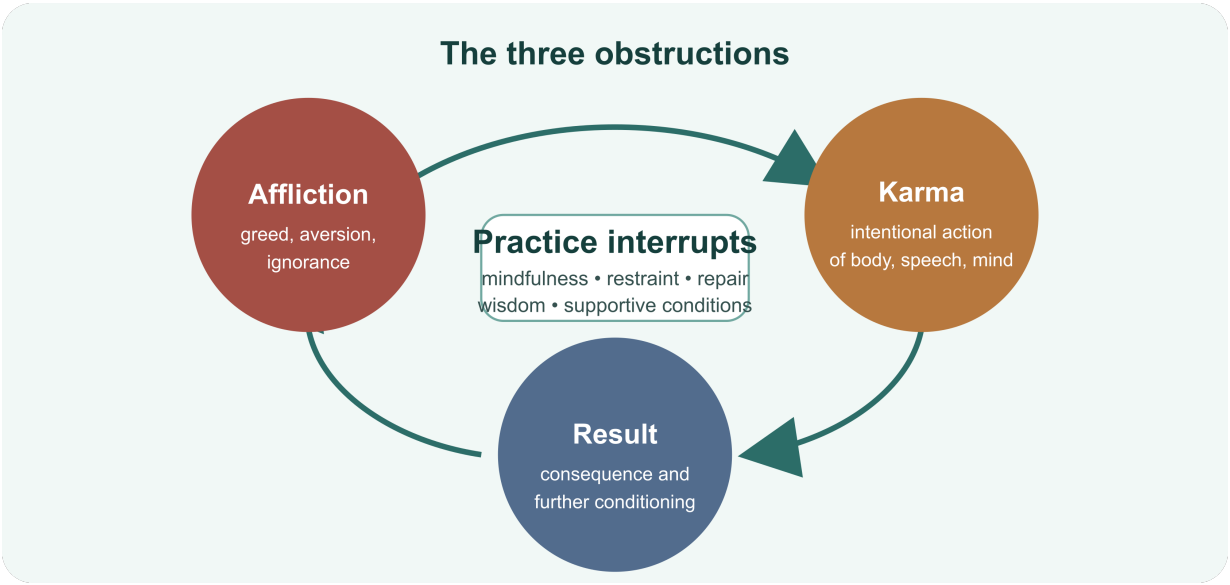
Source pages 23 to 24

What is happening?

The liturgy organises an immense range of wrongdoing into three connected obstructions: afflictions, karma and painful results.

Why is it done?

This turns a catalogue of faults into a diagnosis. If a practitioner sees only the painful result, the inner cause may continue. If they analyse affliction but ignore conduct, insight remains abstract.



What does it mean?

- An affliction disturbs clear awareness.
- Karma is the intentional action it conditions.
- A result is the consequence and further conditioning that follow.

Each can feed the next. The cycle can also be interrupted at every point through mindfulness, restraint, repair, wisdom and supportive conditions.

10. The seven kinds of mind

Source pages 24 to 31

What is happening?

The assembly cultivates seven attitudes before the detailed confession.

Attitude	Practical meaning
Remorse and shame	Admit that the action fell below one's ethical capacity.
Fear	Take consequences seriously instead of assuming they can be avoided.
Dispassion	See that compulsive pleasure and identity cannot provide lasting security.
Bodhi mind	Make reform part of awakening for all beings.
Equality of friend and foe	Refuse to limit compassion to people one likes.
Gratitude to the Buddha	Repay the teaching by practising and sharing it.
Emptiness of transgression	Take responsibility without fixing anyone as permanently corrupt.

Why is it done?

Repentance can fail through denial, panic, self-hatred, resentment or empty performance. The seven minds create a balance of urgency, compassion and wisdom.

Difficult body imagery

The list of body parts and the nine openings is an ancient contemplation of the body as physical, changing and not fit for idealised attachment. It is not a statement that bodies are morally dirty or that bodily care is wrong.

“Friends and foes as equal”

Equality means equal concern for awakening and freedom from suffering. It does not require trusting an unsafe person, abandoning boundaries or pretending that harmful conduct is acceptable.

“Transgressions are empty”

The text says transgressions arise and cease through conditions. This is not an escape from accountability. It explains why accountability can lead to change.

11. Repentance for the obstruction of afflictions

Source pages 32 to 42

What is happening?

The first of the three obstructions becomes the focus. The text begins with greed, anger and ignorance, then expands into a long sequence of numbered lists.

Why is it done?

The sheer range prevents a practitioner from reducing wrongdoing to a few obvious acts. Affliction includes views, habits, doubts, emotional reactions and subtle attachments.

How to read the numbered lists

Treat them as a map of comprehensiveness, not a memory test. A few groups deserve immediate recognition:

- three poisons: greed, hatred and ignorance;
- five coverings: sense desire, ill will, dullness, restlessness and doubt;
- six senses: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body and mind;
- eight sufferings: birth, ageing, illness, death, separation from what is loved, meeting what is disliked, not getting what is wanted and distress connected with clinging to the five aggregates;
- ten afflictions: a scholastic list of primary disturbed states and wrong views;
- eighteen realms: six faculties, six objects and six consciousnesses;
- 108 afflictions: a comprehensive symbolic count of the many ways a mind becomes troubled.

The glossary explains every named group at the level the source supports. It marks lists whose exact members vary or are not supplied.

From confession to vows

The numerical confession is answered by positive aspirations: wisdom, faith, the six perfections, the factors of awakening and the bodhisattva grounds. This structure matters. The practitioner does not merely remove a fault but develops a capacity that makes recurrence less likely.

12. Rectifying the past and cultivating the future

Source pages 43 to 50

What is happening?

The text explains repentance directly: correct the past, cultivate the future, end harmful patterns and give rise to virtues. It asks the practitioner to make the body dignified, the mind reverent and the practice sincere.

Why is it done?

The warning against hidden conduct targets the belief that an unseen act does not matter. Buddhist ethics focuses on what conduct does to the mind and to beings, not only on whether a human authority discovers it.

King Yama and the wardens of hell

The courtroom scene dramatizes unavoidable accountability. Enemies testify about violence and theft; the offender cannot transfer the consequence to family or wealth.

Traditionally, Yama is a ruler or judge connected with the realms of the dead. He is not an all-powerful creator and Buddhist hell is not eternal. Some readers also understand the scene as a psychological image of actions returning through memory, habit, fear and damaged relationships.

The four elements, five aggregates and six senses

The text compares the four elements to snakes, the five aggregates to bandits and the six senses to an empty formation. These are warnings against clinging. They do not teach hatred of the body or the senses.

The positive conclusion is the Noble Eightfold Path: right view, intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness and concentration.

13. Seven Buddhas mantra and exiting repentance

Source pages 51 to 54

What is happening?

The assembly chants the Seven Buddhas Offence-Extinguishing Mantra, recalls the cleansing spring, announces completion of the first scroll and dedicates the merit.

Why is it done?

The mantra seals the confession in a sacred sound formula. The exit prayer prevents an abrupt return to ordinary activity and directs the result towards a wider field.

What does it mean?

The source provides a Sanskrit-derived recitation rather than a prose translation. Its liturgical function is purification. The following verse gives its practical interpretation: the water of samādhi cleanses old enmity, then compassion for oneself becomes compassion for others.

Dedication includes Dharma protectors, spirits, living relatives, ancestors, friends, enemies and all beings. The aspiration to the Pure Land gives this shared benefit a direction towards awakening.

14. Noon Offering Before the Buddhas

Source pages 55 to 58

What is happening?

The assembly invokes the Triple Gem, major Buddhas and bodhisattvas, then chants formulas for transforming food, sweet dew and universal offering.

Why is it done?

Food, one of life's basic supports, becomes a practice of gratitude and impartial generosity. The offering is imagined as reaching Buddhas, sages and all beings in the six realms.

What does it mean?

“Transformation” and “sweet dew” express abundance and relief. The physical portion may be limited, but the vow to nourish and include beings is not.

Beginner notes

- Vulture Peak is the site near ancient Rājagṛha associated with important Mahāyāna teachings, especially the Lotus Sūtra.
- Medicine Master Buddha represents healing and conditions supportive of practice.
- Sanghārāma Bodhisattvas are guardians of Buddhist monasteries and practice places.
- Dhyāna bliss is the joy and ease associated with meditative collectedness.

15. Memorial Altar Dedication

Source pages 59 to 64

What is happening?

The service invokes Amitābha, chants the Heart Sūtra, recites the Rebirth in the Pure Land Dhāraṇī, repeats offering formulas and makes a final dedication.

Why is it done?

The memorial rite joins compassion for the deceased with wisdom about emptiness. Grief is not denied. It is held within a practice that refuses to cling to a fixed self while aspiring towards favourable conditions for awakening.

What does the Heart Sūtra mean here?

Avalokiteśvara sees that the five aggregates are empty of independent essence and crosses beyond suffering. The sūtra then removes every possible object of clinging, even Buddhist teachings and attainment. Its mantra points beyond ordinary conceptual grasping.

This does not say that people or grief are unreal. It says they arise through conditions and cannot be possessed as permanent, separate things.

Why Amitābha?

Amitābha's vows and Pure Land provide a focus for remembrance, trust and aspiration. “Guide and Receiver of the West” expresses the hope that beings will be welcomed into conditions where practice continues without regression.

The closing synthesis

The final wish names Chan, Pure Land, precepts and the patience of equality. It is a compact picture of integrated East Asian Mahāyāna practice:

- Chan steadies and examines the mind;
- Pure Land directs recollection and aspiration;
- precepts guide conduct;
- equality extends patience and compassion without discrimination.

A practical way to carry the text into daily life

After reading a section, use four short questions:

1 What happened? Name the action without disguise.
2 What fed it? Notice craving, aversion, ignorance and surrounding conditions.
3 What can be repaired? Apologise, restore, protect or seek help where appropriate.
4 What will replace it? Make a specific vow and build conditions that support it.

Then dedicate any benefit beyond yourself. This is the ethical movement at the heart of Scroll One.



Part II • Core concepts

The Buddhist world behind the words

These are the ideas a beginner needs before reading or chanting Scroll One.

Who was the Buddha?

Śākyamuni Buddha was Siddhārtha Gautama, a teacher in ancient India. Buddhist traditions remember him as a human being who awakened completely to the causes of suffering and the path that ends them. “Buddha” means “Awakened One”. “Śākyamuni” means “Sage of the Śākya people”.

The Water Repentance honours Śākyamuni as “our teacher”, while also naming other Buddhas. Mahāyāna Buddhism understands Buddhahood as an awakening realised by many Buddhas in different worlds and ages, not a title belonging to only one person.

Buddha, bodhisattva, arhat and sentient being

Term	Beginner meaning
Buddha	One who has fully awakened and perfected wisdom and compassion.
Bodhisattva	One committed to awakening for the benefit of all beings. The word can refer to a great figure such as Avalokiteśvara or to anyone genuinely following the bodhisattva path.
Arhat	A disciple who has overcome the causes of rebirth and attained liberation. Mahāyāna texts honour arhats while presenting full Buddhahood as the universal bodhisattva goal.
Sentient being	Any being capable of experience and suffering. In Buddhist cosmology this includes more than humans and animals.

The Triple Gem

Taking refuge means choosing a reliable spiritual direction:

- Buddha: the awakened teacher and the possibility of awakening;
- Dharma: the teaching and practice that lead out of suffering;
- Sangha: in the strict sense, the community of realised disciples; in common temple use, also the ordained Buddhist community.

Refuge is not a request for a creator deity to take control. It is a commitment to learn from awakening, practise the path and rely on worthy companions.

Karma

Karma means intentional action through body, speech or mind. Such actions shape habits, relationships, experience and, in traditional Buddhist teaching, future rebirth.

Karma is not fate. A past action is one condition among many, and present choices create new conditions. Nor is karma a reason to blame someone for illness, disability, violence or misfortune. An observer normally cannot know the complex causes of another person's suffering.

In Scroll One, karma appears in a practical sequence:

affliction → intentional action → result

Repentance works on this sequence by recognising the affliction, admitting the action, responding to its consequences and creating a different intention.

Body, speech and mind

Buddhist ethics treats conduct as more than visible behaviour.

- Body includes actions such as protecting or harming, giving or stealing.
- Speech includes truthfulness, kindness, division, cruelty and careless talk.
- Mind includes intentions, desires, hostility and views.

The ten unwholesome deeds expand this model: three bodily actions, four kinds of harmful speech and three mental patterns. The aim is not anxious self-surveillance. It is to notice where suffering begins early enough to change course.

The three poisons

The three poisons feed unwholesome action:

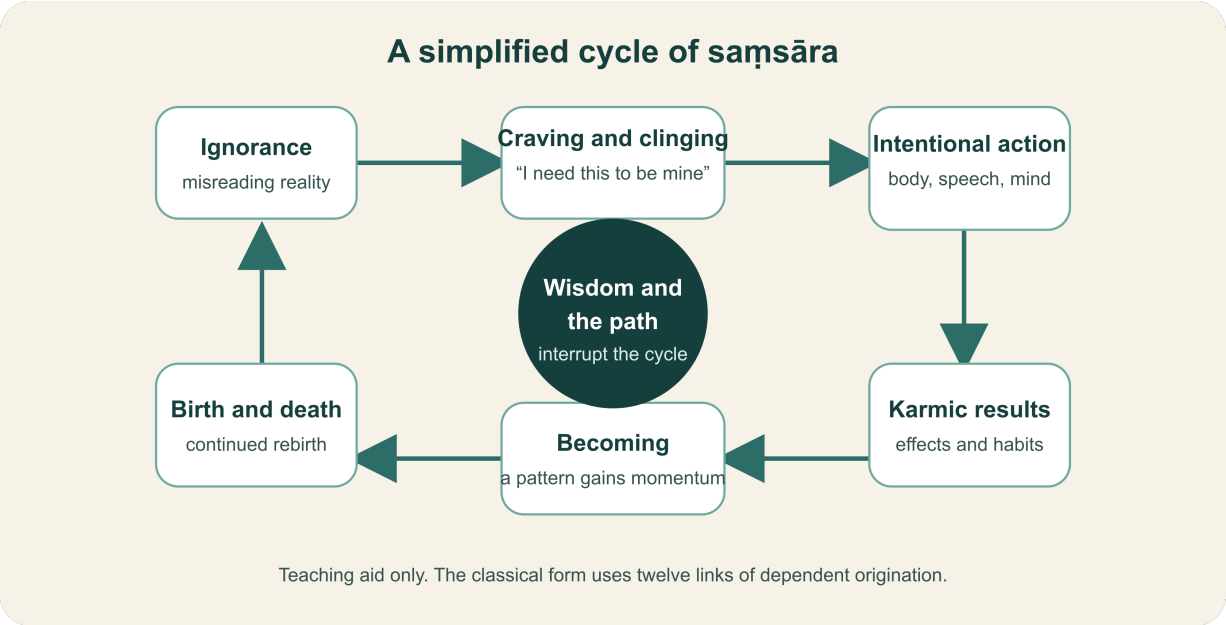
Poison	Meaning	Helpful counter-practice
Greed or craving	Compulsive wanting and possessiveness.	Generosity and contentment.
Hatred or aversion	Hostility, rejection and the urge to harm.	Patience and loving-kindness.
Ignorance or delusion	Misunderstanding reality, especially permanence, self and consequences.	Study, attention and wisdom.

They are called poisons because they distort the mind and spread suffering. They are conditions to be understood and transformed, not a permanent identity.

Saṃsāra and rebirth

Saṃsāra is the continuing cycle of birth and death under the influence of ignorance, craving and karma. Even a pleasant life within saṃsāra remains unstable because its conditions change.

The companion's cycle diagram is deliberately simplified:

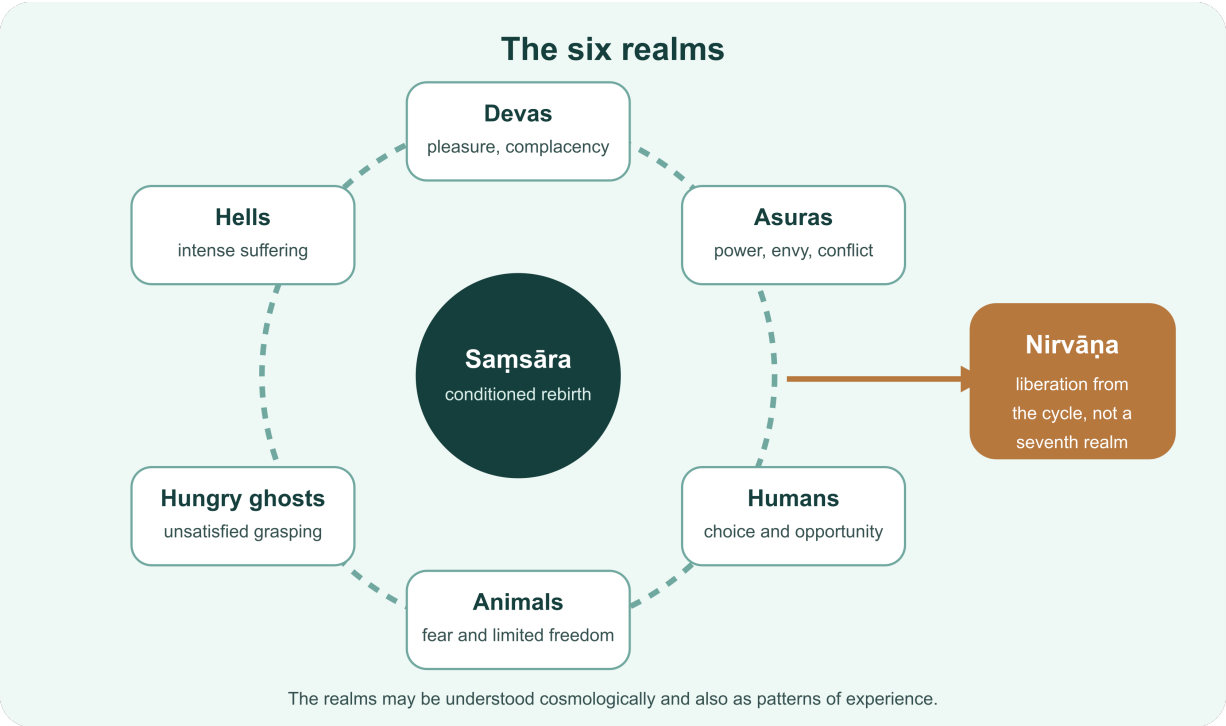


The fuller teaching of dependent origination uses twelve links. Its central point is that suffering arises dependently. When the supporting conditions cease, the suffering process can cease.

The six realms

The liturgy speaks of six broad modes of rebirth:

Realm	Traditional character	Why it is not liberation
Devas	Very pleasurable, long lives.	Pleasure can encourage complacency and eventually ends.
Asuras	Power, competition, envy and conflict.	Strength remains bound to comparison and hostility.
Humans	A mixture of pleasure, pain, choice and reflection.	Human life is impermanent, but its balance makes practice especially possible.
Animals	Vulnerability, fear, limited freedom and survival pressure.	Conditions make sustained understanding and choice difficult.
Hungry ghosts	Insatiable hunger and frustrated grasping.	Wanting cannot be satisfied by obtaining more of the same.
Hells	Intense pain, terror and confinement.	Suffering overwhelms the opportunity for calm practice, though it is not eternal.



The realms may be understood cosmologically and also as patterns of experience.

Many Buddhists understand these as real cosmological rebirths. Some also use them as descriptions of mental and social worlds experienced now. These readings can coexist. In either case, no realm is permanent and none equals nirvāṇa.

Human birth is called precious because it combines moral agency, awareness of suffering and access to the Dharma. This is an opportunity, not a claim that human beings are more worthy of compassion.

Nirvāṇa

Nirvāṇa is liberation from greed, hatred, delusion and the rebirth they sustain. It is not simply a pleasant place after death and not the destruction of a permanent soul. Buddhism denies that such an unchanging soul can be found in the first place.

Texts often describe nirvāṇa through what has ended: grasping, fear, distortion and suffering. They also use positive language such as peace and freedom. Ordinary concepts cannot fully contain it.

Pure Land

A Pure Land is a Buddha-field shaped by a Buddha's vows and awakening. Scroll One focuses on Sukhāvatī, Amitābha Buddha's Western Pure Land of Ultimate Bliss.

Pure Land practice commonly includes trusting Amitābha's vows, reciting his name, cultivating virtue, making an aspiration for rebirth there and dedicating merit. The aim is not endless heavenly pleasure. Sukhāvatī provides unusually favourable conditions in which awakening can continue without falling back.

Is the Pure Land one of the six realms?

Not in the ordinary sense. The six realms describe conditioned rebirth driven by karma and affliction. Amitābha's Pure Land is presented in Mahāyāna sources as a Buddha-field oriented towards non-retrogression and liberation. Traditions differ in how they describe its ultimate status, but it should not be reduced to “Buddhist heaven”.

Repentance and reform

The English title uses “repentance”, but the Chinese term chànhuǐ carries two linked ideas: acknowledging past wrong and changing future conduct.

A complete practice includes:

1 honestly recognising harm;
2 feeling appropriate remorse without self-hatred;
3 disclosing rather than concealing the fault;
4 resolving not to repeat it;
5 repairing harm where possible;
6 cultivating the opposite wholesome quality;
7 understanding that both the action and the person arose through conditions and can change.

There is no creator deity who cancels a sin. Repentance changes the mind and behaviour that support harmful karma. Its images of cleansing describe moral and mental purification.

Chinese Buddhist teaching often distinguishes two connected dimensions:

- repentance in practice: prostration, confession, restraint, offerings and vows;
- repentance through principle: insight that transgressions and the self have no fixed independent nature.

Scroll One contains both.

Merit and dedication

Merit is the beneficial spiritual potential cultivated by wholesome action, such as generosity, ethical conduct, meditation, chanting or helping others. It is not a currency stored by a cosmic accountant.

To dedicate merit is to direct the benefit and aspiration beyond oneself. The liturgy dedicates merit to family, ancestors, deceased beings, friends, enemies and all sentient beings. This expresses gratitude, solidarity and the bodhisattva refusal to keep practice self-centred.

Buddhist traditions explain the mechanics of transfer in different ways. For a beginner, the safest meaning is that practitioners deliberately include others in the purpose, prayer and beneficial consequences of what they have done.

The six senses

Buddhism counts the mind as the sixth sense. Each sense process has three parts: a faculty, an object and the consciousness that arises when conditions meet.

The six senses

faculty + object + consciousness = contact

Faculty	Object	Consciousness
Eye	forms and colours	visual consciousness
Ear	sounds	auditory consciousness
Nose	odours	olfactory consciousness
Tongue	tastes	taste consciousness
Body	touch, pressure, temperature	tactile consciousness
Mind	thoughts, memories, images and other mental objects	mental consciousness

Together the six faculties, six objects and six consciousnesses are called the eighteen realms.

Faculty	Object	Consciousness
eye	visible form and colour	visual consciousness
ear	sound	auditory consciousness
nose	odour	olfactory consciousness
tongue	taste	taste consciousness
body	touch, pressure, temperature and movement	tactile consciousness
mind	thoughts, memories, images and other mental objects	mental consciousness

The source sometimes calls the objects “six dusts”. Dust is a metaphor for the way grasping at experience can cloud the mind. A sight or sound is not morally bad by itself.

The eighteen realms are these six faculties, six objects and six consciousnesses together. The model helps a practitioner observe experience as a conditioned process rather than immediately treating it as “me” or “mine”.

The five aggregates

The Heart Sūtra analyses a person as five changing groups:

1 form: the body and material form;
2 feeling or sensation: pleasant, unpleasant or neutral tone;
3 perception: recognising and labelling;
4 volitional formations: intentions, habits and mental activities;
5 consciousness: awareness of an object through a sense.

No single aggregate is a permanent self, and no permanent self can be found apart from them. This does not deny a person's everyday existence. It challenges the idea of an independent, unchanging core.

Emptiness

Emptiness means lack of independent, permanent essence. A flower depends on seed, soil, water, light, time and perception. A harmful habit depends on triggers, views, choices and repetition. Because these things are conditioned, they can change.

Emptiness therefore avoids two extremes:

- things do not exist as fixed, isolated substances;
- things are not meaningless or causally ineffective.

In repentance, this means: the action matters, but it does not define an eternal self.

Attachment

Attachment is not every form of care or enjoyment. It is clinging that demands a person, object, view or identity provide lasting security despite change. It can turn love into possession, conviction into rigidity and pleasure into compulsion.

Non-attachment does not mean indifference. A bodhisattva cares deeply while trying not to control what cannot be possessed.

Bodhi mind and Buddha-nature

Bodhi mind, or bodhicitta, is the resolve to attain full awakening for the benefit of all beings. It changes repentance from private guilt into a path of compassion.

Buddha-nature is the Mahāyāna teaching that awakening is possible for sentient beings. Traditions explain it in different ways. It should not be mistaken for a hidden permanent soul. In this guide it means that no being is fixed forever in delusion.

Offerings, incense, bells and prostrations

- Incense represents ethical conduct, concentration and an intention spreading through the Dharma realm.
- Flowers represent beauty, generosity and impermanence because they blossom and fade.
- Food offerings train gratitude and generosity and are ritually extended to all kinds of beings.
- Bells gather attention, mark transitions and support a shared pace.
- Prostrations express refuge, gratitude and humility through the body. They are not worship of a creator.
- Joined palms bring two sides together and embody collected attention and respect.
- Circumambulation means walking respectfully around a sacred focus while chanting or recollecting the teaching.

Repeated recitation is a training of attention and intention. The number three often marks the Triple Gem or a complete ritual affirmation. The number 108 is a traditional comprehensive count of afflictions, which is why beads and bell strikes often use it.

Mantra and dhāraṇī

A mantra is a sacred formula used to focus and protect the mind. A dhāraṇī is a related formula associated with retaining a teaching or invoking a ritual purpose.

The source prints several formulas in romanised Sanskrit or a Sanskrit-derived liturgical form. Their sounds have passed through Indian, Central Asian and Chinese transmission. A neat word-for-word English translation is not always secure. The companion therefore explains what each formula is doing in the ritual and preserves the source spelling for recitation.



Part III • Buddhas and bodhisattvas

Names, stories, images, pronunciation and practice pathways

Pronunciations are practical English approximations. They do not reproduce every distinction in Sanskrit, Mandarin or Vietnamese.

Four titles first

Title	Say it like	Meaning
Buddha	BOOD-uh	An Awakened One.
Tathāgata	tuh-THAH-guh-tuh	“Thus Come One”, a title of a Buddha.
Bodhisattva	boh-dee-SUT-vuh	One committed to Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings.
Mahāsattva	muh-HAH-SUT-vuh	“Great being”, an honorific for an advanced bodhisattva.

Principal Buddhas

Śākyamuni Buddha

Say it like: SHAH-kyah-MOO-nee BOOD-uh
Name meaning: Sage of the Śākya people
Recognise him: a monastic Buddha, often touching the earth with his right hand



Śākyamuni is the historical teacher of our world. Born Siddhārtha Gautama in ancient India, he left a privileged life, trained with other seekers, rejected both indulgence and punishing self-denial, awakened beneath the bodhi tree and taught a path out of suffering.

Scroll One calls him “our teacher”. This distinguishes him from the many Buddhas of other ages and worlds invoked in the service.

Why his name is invoked: to take refuge in the teacher who made the path known in this world.

Interesting fact: “Buddha” is a title, not a surname. Śākyamuni is also the seventh of the Seven Ancient Buddhas named in the liturgy.

Practice pathway: see suffering clearly, understand its causes and train in the path that ends them.

Artwork: seventeenth-century Chinese bronze, National Museum in Warsaw. CC0 image via Wikimedia Commons.

Vairocana Buddha

Say it like: vie-ROH-chah-nah BOOD-uh
Name meaning: Illuminator, or the one who shines throughout
Recognise him: a central cosmic Buddha, sometimes forming a wisdom-fist hand gesture



Vairocana embodies the Dharma body, awakened reality and wisdom present without limit. He is especially important in the Flower Adornment Sūtra world of vast, interpenetrating Buddha-fields.

The universal offerings in Scroll One fit this vision: one flower becomes limitless offerings, and a single act is understood within the whole Dharma realm.

Why his name is invoked: to illuminate hidden motives and place personal reform within a reality larger than the individual.

Interesting fact: Vairocana is often associated with Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra. Wisdom and practice reveal the awakened reality he represents.

Practice pathway: bring confusion into the light, then let clear seeing reshape conduct.

Artwork: Vairocana at Longmen Grottoes, China. Mario Biondi, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons.

Amitābha Buddha

Say it like: ah-mee-TAH-bhah BOOD-uh
Name meaning: Infinite Light
Amitāyus: ah-mee-TAH-yoos, Infinite Life
Recognise him: seated in meditation or standing to welcome beings, often with Avalokiteśvara and Mahāsthāmaprāpta



Mahāyāna scriptures tell that Amitābha was once the bodhisattva Dharmākara. He made forty-eight vows to establish Sukhāvatī, the Western Pure Land of Ultimate Bliss, as an exceptionally supportive place for awakening.

Scroll One turns towards Amitābha in its dedication and memorial rite. Recollection of his name gathers attention, while aspiration for the Pure Land directs practice towards non-retrogression and liberation.

Why his name is invoked: for mindful recollection, confidence in awakening, care for the deceased and aspiration to favourable conditions for practice.

Interesting fact: Amitābha and Amitāyus are two aspects of the same Buddha, emphasising infinite light and infinite life. “Guide and Receiver of the West” is also Amitābha.

Practice pathway: return a scattered mind to one wholesome direction, then include all beings in the aspiration.

Artwork: ninth-century painting of Amitābha with eight great bodhisattvas. Public domain via Wikimedia Commons.

Medicine Master Buddha

Say it like: MED-ih-sin MAS-ter BOOD-uh
Sanskrit: Bhaiṣajyaguru, approximately bye-SHAJ-yah-GOO-roo
Name meaning: Medicine Teacher
Recognise him: a Buddha holding a medicine bowl or medicinal plant, often blue in Tibetan art



Medicine Master Buddha made twelve vows concerned with bodily and mental suffering, material need, ethical confusion and conditions supportive of the path. Healing in this tradition is broader than the promise of a cure. It includes wise treatment, relief from fear, ethical reform and a life used well.

Scroll One invokes him during the Noon Offering as “disaster-eradicating and longevity-extending”. This is a traditional devotional title, not a substitute for medical care.

Why his name is invoked: to support healing, protection and the conditions in which wisdom and compassion can grow.

Interesting fact: his full title links healing with lapis-lazuli radiance, a clear blue brilliance associated with purity.

Practice pathway: identify the cause of harm, apply a fitting remedy and use restored strength to help others.

Artwork: Chinese mural of Medicine Master Buddha and his assembly, about 1319, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain_-_Google_Art_Project.jpg).

Maitreya

Say it like: my-TRAY-yah
Name meaning: the Loving or Friendly One
Recognise him: a princely bodhisattva, or in East Asia through the smiling monk Budai



Maitreya is the bodhisattva who will become the next Buddha in this world after Śākyamuni's teaching has disappeared. He is traditionally understood to be teaching in Tuṣita Heaven while awaiting his final birth.

Scroll One calls him “future descending-birth, honoured Maitreya Buddha”, speaking from the perspective of his future awakening.

Why his name is invoked: to cultivate loving-kindness, patience and confidence that the Dharma can appear again in difficult times.

Interesting fact: the familiar round-bellied smiling figure in many East Asian temples is Budai, a Chinese monk later regarded as a manifestation of Maitreya. It is not the only way Maitreya is represented.

Practice pathway: let repentance open a constructive future rather than remain fixed on the past.

Artwork: fifteenth-century painting of Maitreya, Rubin Museum of Art. Public domain via Wikimedia Commons.

Prabhūtaratna Buddha

Say it like: prah-BOO-tah-RUT-nah BOOD-uh
Name meaning: Many Treasures
Recognise him: seated beside Śākyamuni inside or above a treasure stūpa



In the Lotus Sūtra, Prabhūtaratna's treasure stūpa rises from the earth wherever that teaching is proclaimed. He invites Śākyamuni to sit beside him and bears witness to the teaching.

Scroll One includes both the stūpa and Prabhūtaratna in its Samantabhadra visualisation and Buddha-name litany.

Why his name is invoked: to place the practice before an awakened witness and affirm the continuity of the Dharma.

Interesting fact: East Asian images of two Buddhas seated together usually depict this scene, not two unrelated teachers.

Practice pathway: stop hiding the truth and make reform accountable before a worthy witness.

Artwork: Śākyamuni and Prabhūtaratna, China, dated 609. Gary Todd, CC0 via Wikimedia Commons.jpg).

Principal bodhisattvas

Avalokiteśvara Bodhisattva

Say it like: ah-vah-loh-kee-TAYSH-vah-rah
Common English or Chinese name: Guanyin, gwahn-yin
Name meaning: commonly understood in East Asia as the one who observes the cries of the world
Recognise this figure: a lotus, vase of pure water, willow branch, many arms, or a small Amitābha image in the crown



Avalokiteśvara embodies compassion that hears suffering and responds in whatever form can help. In the Heart Sūtra recited during the memorial rite, this bodhisattva also embodies profound wisdom by seeing the five aggregates as empty.

Why the name is invoked: for responsive compassion joined with insight.

Interesting fact: Indian images are often masculine. In China, Vietnam and other parts of East Asia, Guanyin is often represented in a feminine form. These are not separate bodhisattvas.

Practice pathway: listen fully before defending yourself, then respond in a way that actually reduces suffering.

Artwork: Guanyin, China, late seventeenth to early eighteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Mañjuśrī Bodhisattva

Say it like: mun-joo-SHREE
Name meaning: Wondrous Glory or Wondrous Auspiciousness
Recognise this figure: a flaming sword, wisdom scripture, lotus or lion mount



Mañjuśrī embodies the wisdom that recognises emptiness and cuts through confused views. In Mahāyāna sūtras he often asks or answers the question that exposes the heart of a teaching.

Why the name is invoked: to understand the conditions behind harmful action and avoid mistaking shame for wisdom.

Interesting fact: the sword is not a weapon against people. It represents insight cutting through ignorance. The lion expresses the fearless voice of the Dharma.

Practice pathway: ask which assumption, story or misperception allowed the action to seem reasonable.

Artwork: traditional image of lion-riding Mañjuśrī. Public domain via Wikimedia Commons.

Samantabhadra Bodhisattva

Say it like: sah-MUN-tah-BHAD-rah
Name meaning: Universal Worthy or All-encompassing Good
Recognise this figure: a white elephant, often with six tusks



Samantabhadra embodies vows carried into practice. His ten great vows include homage, praise, offering, repentance, rejoicing in goodness, requesting the teaching, asking Buddhas to remain, learning, helping beings and dedicating merit.

Scroll One gives him its richest visualisation and invokes him at major transitions.

Why the name is invoked: to turn remorse into sustained compassionate conduct.

Interesting fact: Fo Guang Shan explains the six tusks as the six perfections. The white elephant joins purity with strong, steady movement.

Practice pathway: make the next wholesome action specific enough to perform and repeat.

Artwork: Samantabhadra riding an elephant, China, twelfth to fourteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Mahāsthāmaprāpta Bodhisattva

Say it like: mah-HAH-stah-mah-PRAHP-tah
Name meaning: Arrival of Great Strength
Recognise this figure: beside Amitābha, often with a water-vase emblem in the crown



Mahāsthāmaprāpta represents the strength of wisdom, concentration and continuous recollection. Along with Avalokiteśvara, this bodhisattva assists Amitābha in the Western Pure Land.

Why the name is invoked: to gather a scattered mind and sustain wholesome recollection.

Interesting fact: the “great strength” is not domination. It is the power of a mind no longer pulled in every direction.

Practice pathway: choose a wholesome recollection and return to it until it becomes stronger than the old reaction.

Artwork: Mahāsthāmaprāpta, China, late seventeenth to early eighteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva

Say it like: kshih-tee-GAHR-bhah
Name meaning: Earth Treasury
Recognise this figure: a monastic with a staff and wish-fulfilling jewel



Kṣitigarbha is renowned for immense vows to help beings in the hells and other states of severe suffering. The Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva Sūtra also connects the practice with gratitude towards parents and care for the deceased.

Why the name is invoked: to extend responsibility and compassion to beings who seem most difficult to reach.

Interesting fact: unlike princely bodhisattvas covered in jewels, Kṣitigarbha often appears as a simple monastic. The image suggests closeness to places of suffering.

Practice pathway: do not abandon the person or situation merely because help will be slow and difficult.

Artwork: Kṣitigarbha, Korea, first half of the fourteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Mahāvyūha Bodhisattva

Say it like: mah-HAH-VYOO-hah
Name meaning: Great Adornment or Great Array



Scroll One includes Mahāvyūha in its repeated bodhisattva litany but gives no independent story or identifying attributes. “Adornment” in Mahāyāna often means the beauty created by accumulated virtues and compassionate deeds.

No securely standard portrait has been identified for this figure. The symbolic lotus avoids mislabelling a generic image.

Practice pathway: adorn life through conduct rather than appearance alone.

The Seven Ancient Buddhas



Scroll One invokes a traditional succession of seven Buddhas. The first three belong to a previous world age. The final four, ending with Śākyamuni, belong to the present fortunate age. Their recitation places one act of repentance within a long continuity of awakening.

Buddha	Say it like	Note
Vipaśyin	vih-PUSH-yin	Often understood as Clear-Seeing.
Śikhin	SHEE-kin	A past Buddha, not Śikhin Brahmā.
Viśvabhū	VISH-vah-BOO	A Buddha of an earlier world age.
Krakucchanda	krah-koot-CHUN-dah	First Buddha of the present fortunate age.
Kanakamuni	kah-nah-kah-MOO-nee	Second Buddha of the present fortunate age.
Kāśyapa Buddha	KAH-shyah-pah	Buddha immediately before Śākyamuni, not the disciple Mahākāśyapa.
Śākyamuni	SHAH-kyah-MOO-nee	The historical teacher of our world.

Artwork: Chinese sculpture of the Seven Buddhas, Tang to Five Dynasties period. CC0 via Wikimedia Commons.jpg).

Buddhas in the repeated litany

The source names several Buddhas without giving stories or distinctive iconography. Their liturgical purpose is clear: they form an awakened assembly before whom confession and vows are made. The guide does not invent biographies.

Name	Easy pronunciation	Secure beginner note
Nāgagotrodārajñānarāja	NAH-gah-goh-troh-DAH-rah-NYAH-nah-RAH-jah	A Buddha whose long title is associated with a noble dragon or nāga lineage and wisdom.
Nāgeśvararāja	nah-GAYSH-vah-rah-RAH-jah	“Sovereign King of Nāgas” or “Dragon Sovereign King”.
Buddhapuṇḍarīkadhyaneśvararāja	BOOD-dhah-poon-dah-REE-kah-DYAH-nay-shvah-rah-RAH-jah	A title joining the awakening lotus, meditation and sovereign mastery.
Kasayadhvaja	kah-SAH-yah-dvah-jah	“Banner of the monastic robe”, an image of renunciation and the Dharma made visible.
Siṃhanāda	SING-hah-NAH-dah	“Lion's Roar”, an image of fearless Dharma teaching.

Ritual and collective invocations

Some titles sound like individual people but function more naturally as invocations of an image, quality or assembly.

Invocation	Meaning in context
Incense Cloud Canopy Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	The fragrant offering imagined as a vast canopy reaching awakened assemblies.
Precious Uḍumbara Blossom Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	An auspicious blossom famous in Buddhist literature for rarity, used here in an offering and homage context. No secure individual biography is supplied.
Equal Awakening Stage Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	Advanced bodhisattvas at the stage immediately preceding complete Buddhahood.
Pure Cool Ground Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	A memorial invocation of purity and relief from the “heat” of affliction.
Dhyāna Bliss Treasury Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	A personified image of the deep joy and ease associated with meditation.
Sanghārāma Bodhisattvas	Protectors of monasteries and Buddhist practice places.



Part IV • Pronunciation

Practical English cues for names and terms

This guide aims for a confident, recognisable first reading. It is not a substitute for listening to a temple officiant or trained language speaker.

Quick Sanskrit key

Printed form	Approximate sound
ā	“ah”, held a little longer
ī	“ee”
ū	“oo”
ś, ṣ	“sh” for an easy first reading
c	“ch”
j	“j” as in “jam”
ñ	“ny” as in “canyon”
kṣ	roughly “ksh”
ṃ, ṁ	a nasal sound coloured by the next consonant
bh, dh, gh	a consonant followed by a light breath; plain “b”, “d” or “g” is acceptable for a beginner

Capital letters below show the strongest syllable. Hyphens mark comfortable reading units rather than exact linguistic syllables.

Names used often

Name	Easy English pronunciation
Śākyamuni	SHAH-kyah-MOO-nee
Vairocana	vie-ROH-chah-nah
Amitābha	ah-mee-TAH-bhah
Amitāyus	ah-mee-TAH-yoos
Maitreya	my-TRAY-yah
Bhaiṣajyaguru	bye-SHAJ-yah-GOO-roo
Avalokiteśvara	ah-vah-loh-kee-TAYSH-vah-rah
Mañjuśrī	mun-joo-SHREE
Samantabhadra	sah-MUN-tah-BHAD-rah
Mahāsthāmaprāpta	mah-HAH-stah-mah-PRAHP-tah
Kṣitigarbha	kshih-tee-GAHR-bhah
Prabhūtaratna	prah-BOO-tah-RUT-nah
Mahāvyūha	mah-HAH-VYOO-hah

Important Buddhist terms

Term	Easy English pronunciation
Buddha	BOOD-uh
bodhisattva	boh-dee-SUT-vuh
mahāsattva	muh-HAH-SUT-vuh
Dharma	DAR-muh
Sangha	SUNG-huh
Tathāgata	tuh-THAH-guh-tuh
Mahāyāna	muh-hah-YAH-nuh
samādhi	suh-MAH-dee
saṃsāra	sum-SAH-ruh
nirvāṇa	neer-VAH-nuh
karma	KAR-muh
sūtra	SOO-truh
dhāraṇī	DHAH-ruh-nee
pāramitā	pah-ruh-mee-TAH
prajñā	PRUJ-nyah
Sukhāvatī	soo-KHAH-vah-tee
Śāriputra	SHAH-ree-POO-truh
Uḍumbara	oo-DOOM-bah-rah
dhyāna	DYAH-nuh
stūpa	STOO-puh

Short chant cues

Source form	Easy reading cue	Meaning or function
namaḥ / namo	NUH-muh / NUH-moh	Homage, honour or taking refuge.
oṃ	ohm	A sacred opening syllable in many mantras.
svāhā	SWAH-hah	A traditional mantra ending, often marking offering or completion.
gate gate pāragate pārasaṃgate bodhi svāhā	GAH-tay GAH-tay PAH-rah-gah-tay PAH-rah-sum-gah-tay BOH-dee SWAH-hah	The closing mantra of the Heart Sūtra. Its common interpretive sense points to going beyond, fully beyond, into awakening.

The other dhāraṇīs in the source are best learned by listening to the officiant. Their printed forms reflect a long route of oral and written transmission, so an English cue can easily create more confusion than help.

A small Vietnamese name bridge

The source PDF is not Vietnamese. This table is included only because an English reader may hear these names at a Vietnamese Mahāyāna temple.

Vietnamese tones matter, and the cues below are deliberately rough. Northern and Southern pronunciation differ, especially where a written d may sound closer to English “z” in the north and “y” in the south.

English or Sanskrit name	Vietnamese name	Rough cue for recognition
Śākyamuni Buddha	Phật Thích Ca Mâu Ni	fuht tick kah mow nee
Amitābha Buddha	Phật A Di Đà	fuht ah zee-dah or southern ah yee-dah
Avalokiteśvara	Quán Thế Âm	kwahn tay uhm
Kṣitigarbha	Địa Tạng	zee-uh tahng or southern yee-uh tahng
Maitreya	Di Lặc	zee luck or southern yee luck
Mañjuśrī	Văn Thù	vun too
Samantabhadra	Phổ Hiền	faw hee-en
Medicine Buddha	Phật Dược Sư	fuht zuhrk suh or southern yuhrk suh

Nam Mô A Di Đà Phật

Rough cue: nahm moh ah zee-dah fuht, with southern Di often nearer yee.

Meaning: “Homage to Amitābha Buddha” or “I take refuge in Amitābha Buddha”. It is a Vietnamese form of Buddha-name recitation. Listen and follow the local temple's rhythm and tones rather than forcing the English cue.



Part V • Glossary

A consolidated beginner reference for all three scrolls

This glossary is consolidated from the English translation in all three scrolls (175 PDF pages in total). Repeated terms are listed once. Sanskrit spellings generally follow the PDFs. Explanations describe how a term is used in this Chinese Mahāyāna Buddhist liturgy; they do not imply that every Buddhist tradition uses it in exactly the same way.

For additional Buddhist terminology, visit the Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center glossary.

How to use this glossary

Look up a word, numbered teaching, ritual action, title, place, or unusual expression in the alphabetical table. Cross-references are included in the explanation itself. Where the English edition uses an unusual translation, the explanation gives the more familiar Buddhist term. A few compressed phrases cannot be identified with certainty; these are described carefully and collected after the table.

Only the English translation was used to select glossary entries. Chinese characters and transliteration were consulted in the second pass solely to identify what an unclear English label refers to. The non-English mantra and dhāraṇī syllables have not been translated.

The six senses at a glance

In Buddhist analysis, the mind is the sixth sense. Each faculty meets a corresponding object, and the relevant consciousness arises. Together these form the basic structure of ordinary experience.

Sense faculty	Sense object	Consciousness	Everyday example
Eye	Forms, colours, and shapes	Visual consciousness	Seeing a flower
Ear	Sounds	Auditory consciousness	Hearing a bell

Sense faculty	Sense object	Consciousness	Everyday example
Nose	Odours	Olfactory consciousness	Smelling incense
Tongue	Tastes	Taste consciousness	Tasting tea
Body	Tangible objects: pressure, texture, temperature, and pain	Tactile consciousness	Feeling warmth
Mind	Mental objects: thoughts, memories, images, emotions, and ideas	Mental consciousness	Remembering a conversation

The relationship can be summarized as:

> sense faculty + sense object + corresponding consciousness → contact → feeling → possible craving, aversion, or confusion

The sequence is not a claim that every experience must end in craving or aversion. Practice develops mindfulness and wisdom so that contact and feeling can be known without automatically turning into grasping or rejection. “Mind” here means the faculty that knows mental events; it is not a permanent soul.

Consolidated glossary

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
“3x”	Repeat the preceding chant, name, or action three times.
Affinities; virtuous affinities	Relationships and circumstances created by past and present actions. “Creating affinities” means forming helpful connections with people and with Buddhist practice.
Affliction	A mental state such as greed, anger, jealousy, pride, or ignorance that disturbs the mind and leads to suffering or harmful action.
Afflictions of views and thoughts; “thoughts after seeing the truth”	A distinction between mistaken beliefs cut through by insight and subtler emotional habits removed through continued cultivation. The PDF’s phrase “thoughts after seeing the truth” is awkward in English.
Ahaha, Ababa, Atata, and Alala Hells	Names representing cries or sounds made by beings suffering in extreme cold. They belong to the traditional cold-hell imagery, not to an ordinary spoken vocabulary.
Aloeswood; turuṣka incense	Aromatic materials burned as valuable ritual offerings. Turuṣka is an old name generally associated with frankincense or a similar imported resin.
Amitābha Buddha; Infinite Life Tathāgata; Guide and Receiver of the West	The Buddha of Infinite Light and Infinite Life, believed to welcome beings who aspire to rebirth in his Western Pure Land. These are different titles for the same Buddha in this text.
Ānāpānasmṛti	Mindfulness of breathing: calmly attending to inhalation and exhalation as a meditation practice.
Ancestral Master	A respected teacher in the historical lineage through which a Buddhist tradition or practice was transmitted.
Anuttarāsamyaksaṃbodhi	“Unsurpassed, complete awakening”: the full enlightenment attained by a Buddha.
Arhat	A person who has awakened through the Buddha’s teaching and is liberated from the cycle of rebirth. In Mahāyāna texts, this attainment is respected but distinguished from the bodhisattva path to full Buddhahood.
Asaṃkhyeya; asaṃkhyeya kalpa	Asaṃkhyeya means “incalculable.” An asaṃkhyeya kalpa is an unimaginably long span of time.
Asura	A powerful, competitive, and often jealous being in Buddhist cosmology, sometimes translated as a demigod or titan.
Attachment to precepts, rites, and rituals	Mistaking rules or ceremonies for ends in themselves, or believing that outward observance alone guarantees liberation. It does not mean that all precepts or rituals are rejected.
Avalokiteśvara Bodhisattva; Great Compassion; Compassionate Lord; Great Compassionate One	The bodhisattva who embodies compassion and responds to the suffering of beings. In Chinese Buddhism this figure is commonly known as Guanyin.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Avīci Hell; Uninterrupted Hell	The most severe hell realm in the cosmology used by the text, where suffering is described as continuous.
Beginningless time	A conventional way of saying that no first beginning of the cycle of ignorance, karma, and rebirth can be identified.
Benefactor families	Lay donors and their households who support the temple or service and for whom blessings are dedicated.
Bhagavān; Great Awakened One; Honored One; World-Honored One	Reverential titles for a Buddha. Bhagavān is often rendered “Blessed One”; “Awakened One” explains the basic meaning of “Buddha.”
Bhikṣu	A fully ordained Buddhist monk.
Bhikṣuṇī	A fully ordained Buddhist nun.
Blue-robed child	A youthful ritual or iconographic attendant who presents flowers to the Compassionate Lord. The English text does not identify the figure more precisely.
Bodh Gaya	The place in present-day India where Śākyamuni Buddha attained awakening beneath the bodhi tree.
Bodhi mind; bodhi resolve; Mahāyāna aspiration	The intention to attain full Buddhahood in order to help all beings become free from suffering. Also called bodhicitta.
Bodhi; awakening	Awakening to reality and freedom from ignorance. “Bodhi” is the Sanskrit word commonly translated as enlightenment or awakening.
Bodhisattva	One committed to the path of full Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings. The word can refer to great celestial figures or to human practitioners following this vow.
Bodhisattva precepts	Mahāyāna ethical commitments centred on avoiding harm, cultivating goodness, and acting for the liberation of all beings. Different lineages transmit somewhat different formal lists.
Bodhisattva stages; Ten Grounds; First through Tenth Stages	Progressive levels of realization and compassionate ability on the bodhisattva path. The Ten Grounds are advanced stages leading toward Buddhahood.
Bodhisattva-Mahāsattva	“Bodhisattva, great being”: an emphatic honorific for a highly advanced bodhisattva.
Brahmā; King Brahmā	A high celestial being associated with the form realm. He is powerful and long-lived but is not a creator god in the Buddhist framework of this text.
Buddha	An “awakened one” who has fully overcome ignorance and perfected wisdom and compassion. Śākyamuni is the Buddha of our historical world; the text also invokes many other Buddhas.
Buddha light; clouds of kindness	Devotional metaphors for the wisdom, protection, and compassion of a Buddha reaching and supporting beings.
Buddha nature; awakened nature; proper cause of awakening	The capacity or basis within sentient beings for awakening. It should not be read here as an ordinary permanent ego or soul.
Buddha-land	A realm associated with a Buddha and shaped by that Buddha’s vows and teaching activity. A purified Buddha-land is called a Pure Land.
Buddhadharma; Buddha Dharma	The Buddha’s teaching and the path of practice based on it.
Buddha’s work	Activity that teaches, protects, or otherwise helps beings move toward awakening.
Buddhist names in the repeated litany: Nāgagotrodārajñānarāja, Nāgeśvararāja, Buddhapuṇḍarīkadhyaneśvararāja, Kasayadhvaja, and Siṃhanāda	Buddhas invoked by name in the ritual. The English text does not tell their stories; for a beginner, the important point is that each is honored as a fully awakened Buddha. “Siṃhanāda” means “lion’s roar,” a common image for fearless teaching.
“Calculating every hour and selling the days”	Archaic wording for making profit through accumulating interest over time, especially exploitative moneylending.
Causes and conditions	The many factors on which an event or experience depends. Buddhism uses this phrase to reject the idea that things arise independently or without causes.
Celestial; heavenly being; deva	A being reborn in a heavenly realm because of wholesome karma. Devas enjoy great pleasure and long life but are still impermanent and within saṃsāra.
Chan	The Chinese Buddhist meditation tradition known as Zen in Japanese.
Circumambulation	Walking respectfully around a sacred image, altar, stūpa, or hall, usually keeping it to one’s right.
Compiled Method; repentance method; Dharma method	An organized practice or ritual procedure. “Method” here does not mean a scientific method.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Conditioned existence; conditioned phenomena	Things that arise because of causes and conditions and therefore change and cease.
Confession	Openly acknowledging harmful actions instead of hiding them. In this liturgy it is paired with repentance and a resolve to change.
Contemplation of impurities	Meditation on the body's physical components and impermanence to reduce infatuation and attachment, not to encourage hatred of the body.
Dānapāramitā	The perfection of generosity: developing giving so fully that it supports the bodhisattva path to awakening.
Dedicating merit to the Three Realms	Using wholesome action mainly to seek better rebirth or pleasure within saṃsāra, rather than directing it toward liberation and the benefit of all beings. The text treats this as an incomplete use of merit.
Dedication of merits; dedication verse; dedicative report	Directing the hoped-for benefit of a practice toward other beings and toward awakening, rather than keeping the benefit for oneself alone.
Devas and nāgas; Eightfold Division of Devas and Nāgas	Traditional classes of nonhuman beings who attend and protect the Dharma. The full group commonly includes devas, nāgas, yakṣas, asuras, gandharvas, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, and mahoragas.
Deviant views; wrong views; other paths	Tradition-internal labels for beliefs considered to obstruct liberation, especially denial of ethical cause and effect or attachment to a permanent self. They can sound dismissive when applied to other religions or philosophies.
Dhāraṇī	A sacred recitation intended to retain a teaching, focus the mind, or invoke protection and blessing. Its Sanskrit sounds are often preserved rather than translated word for word.
Dharma	Depending on context: the Buddha's teaching, the truth taught by the Buddha, a particular teaching or practice, or – when written as "dharmas" – phenomena or elements of experience.
Dharma body; non-dual Dharma body	The Buddha understood as ultimate truth or reality itself, not merely as a historical physical body.
Dharma door; Dharma gate	A teaching or practice that provides an entry into understanding and liberation. "Eighty-four thousand Dharma gates" means an immense variety suited to different beings.
Dharma protector	A deity, spirit, or practitioner understood to guard Buddhist teachings, places, and communities.
Dharma realm; Dharma realms	The total field of reality and all beings and phenomena within it. In ritual language, "all Dharma realms" can simply mean everywhere and everything.
Dharma Talk by Officiant	Teaching or closing guidance given by the ritual leader after the liturgy.
Dharma throne; lion throne; jeweled or lotus throne	An elevated ceremonial seat for a Buddha image or teacher. "Lion" suggests fearless authority in teaching, not a throne made for a literal lion.
Dhyāna; meditative concentration	Deep, stable meditation. The Four Dhyānas are progressively quieter states associated with the form realm.
Dīpaṃkara Buddha	A Buddha of the distant past whose name means "Maker of Light." Buddhist tradition says he predicted the future Buddhahood of Śākyamuni.
Dispassion	Freedom from compulsive craving and clinging. It means clear nonattachment, not coldness or lack of care.
Eight Cold and Eight Hot Hells; named hells such as Black String, Mountains of Knives, Trees of Swords, Boiling Cauldron, and Iron Bed	Traditional hell realms whose names describe particular forms of intense suffering. The liturgy uses vivid images to stress the gravity of harmful action. Buddhist readers differ over how literally or symbolically to understand them.
Eight Defilements	A compact list of mental stains. A common eightfold explanation is greed, hatred, delusion, pride, wrong views, doubt, mental dullness, and distraction. "Defilement" means a state that clouds clear awareness.
Eight Delusions; Eight Inversions	Eight ways of seeing qualities backwards. Four take what is impermanent, unsatisfactory, without a fixed self, and impure to be permanent, blissful, a self, and pure. In a Mahāyāna Nirvāṇa Sūtra framework, four more deny the ultimate permanence, bliss, true self, and purity attributed to a Buddha's nirvāṇa.
Eight Difficulties	Eight situations considered especially obstructive to hearing and practicing the Dharma, such as rebirth in painful realms or at a time and place where the teaching is unavailable.
Eight kinds of voices; Four kinds of eloquence	Ideal qualities of awakened speech: a voice that is clear and fitting for listeners, together with unobstructed command of meaning, teaching, expression, and explanation.
Eight Liberations	Eight advanced meditative releases, moving from disciplined contemplation of form through the formless concentrations to complete cessation.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Eight Masteries of the Self	A Mahāyāna expression for the Buddha's complete freedom and ability to manifest and act without the limitations of ordinary clinging. It is not the ordinary ego gaining total control.
Eight Precepts	A one-day or short-term lay discipline: refraining from killing, stealing, sexual activity, false speech, intoxicants, eating after noon, entertainment or adornment, and luxurious beds or seats.
Eight Seasonal Markers	Traditional observance dates tied to the changing seasons. The English text does not state exactly which calendar scheme is intended.
Eight Sufferings	Birth, ageing, illness, death, separation from what one loves, meeting what one dislikes, not getting what one wants, and suffering connected with the five aggregates.
Eight Worldly Winds	Gain and loss, praise and blame, fame and disgrace, pleasure and pain – the changing conditions that can push an unsteady mind around.
Eighteen Distinct Traits	Eighteen qualities traditionally said to distinguish a Buddha's perfect conduct, mindfulness, concentration, wisdom, and liberating activity.
Eighteen Realms	The six sense organs, their six objects, and the six corresponding consciousnesses. Together they describe the structure of ordinary experience.
Eighty-Four Thousand Gates of Affliction	A conventional enormous number representing the full variety of mental defilements. It corresponds to the image of equally numerous Dharma gates that can remedy them.
Eleven Biases; Eleven Pervasive Afflictions	The PDF's "Biases" translates a list of afflictions that spread through many other confused states. Seven concern misunderstanding the truth of suffering – five wrong views, doubt, and ignorance – and four concern its origin – wrong view, attachment to views, doubt, and ignorance.
Eleven Kinds of Emptiness	Eleven applications of insight into the lack of fixed, independent essence. Different scholastic presentations vary, and the PDF does not list the eleven.
Emptiness; empty nature	The teaching that things have no fixed, independent essence; they exist through causes, conditions, parts, and concepts. "Empty" does not mean that nothing exists or that actions have no consequences.
Enmity; karmic enmity; spiteful karma	A hostile relationship believed to have been created by past harm and carried forward through karmic causes. Repentance is presented as a way to end the cycle of retaliation.
Enter the Dharma flow	Become steadily aligned with the teaching and its movement toward awakening. "Flow" is a metaphor, not a physical stream.
Entering Repentance; Exiting Repentance	Formal prayers that open and close a scroll's repentance service.
Equanimity	A balanced, impartial care that does not collapse into favoritism, hatred, or emotional reactivity. It is one of the Four Limitless Minds.
Essence and spirit	Traditional language for a person's vital and conscious aspect. The wording should not automatically be taken as teaching an eternal soul, which Buddhism generally denies.
Eternal night	A metaphor for the long darkness of ignorance and repeated rebirth without awakening.
Eternalism and nihilism	Two rejected extremes: believing in an unchanging eternal self, or believing that persons and actions simply become nothing and therefore have no moral consequences.
Eternally abiding Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha	The Triple Gem understood as an enduring source of refuge beyond the lifespan of any one teacher or institution.
Expedient means; skillful means	A teaching or action adapted to a particular person's needs and capacity in order to guide that person toward liberation.
Field of merit	A person or community toward whom generosity is considered especially spiritually fruitful, just as good soil helps a seed produce a crop.
Five Aggregates	Form or body, sensation, perception, volition or mental formations, and consciousness. Buddhism analyzes a person as these changing processes rather than as a permanent self.
Five celestial attendants; Five Divine Messengers	Signs that awaken a person to life's vulnerability and moral urgency: a helpless infant, an aged person, a sick person, a person undergoing punishment for wrongdoing, and a dead person. "Messengers" is clearer than the PDF's "attendants"; they are reminders, not a household retinue.
Five Coverings	Sense desire, ill will, drowsiness, restlessness and worry, and doubt – mental hindrances that cover clarity and concentration.
Five Degenerations	Five worsening conditions said to mark a troubled age: decline in the age itself, views, afflictions, living beings, and lifespan. "Defiled home of the five degenerations" means this difficult world.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Five Desires	Craving for pleasing sights, sounds, smells, tastes, and touches. Some monastic lists use the phrase more broadly for desired material supports.
Five Eyes	Five increasingly profound ways of “seeing”: ordinary physical sight, heavenly sight, wisdom insight, Dharma insight, and a Buddha’s complete vision.
Five Faculties and Five Powers	Faith, effort, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom. They are “faculties” while developing and “powers” when firmly established.
Five Forms of Stinginess	Clinging possessively to one’s residence, supporters or family, material gains, praise, or knowledge of the Dharma.
Five Grave Deeds	The most serious traditional offenses: killing one’s mother, killing one’s father, killing an arhat, maliciously shedding a Buddha’s blood, and causing a schism in the Sangha.
Five kinds of people	The Chinese phrase in the sexual-conduct passage most likely refers to an ancient Vinaya classification of five types of paṇḍaka or “non-male” person. Those categories were based on premodern ideas about anatomy, castration, sexual function, and bodily transformation; the English edition does not name them individually.
Five Minds	A technical analysis of stages in a moment of perception, commonly described as first impression, searching attention, decision, wholesome or unwholesome response, and continuation. The PDF does not define the term.
Five Parts of the Dharma Body	Five perfected qualities: ethical discipline, concentration, wisdom, liberation, and knowledge or vision of liberation. The PDF once prints “Dhama Body,” apparently a typo for “Dharma Body.”
Five Precepts	Basic lay ethical commitments: refrain from killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, false speech, and intoxicants.
Five pungent vegetables	Strong-smelling plants traditionally restricted in some East Asian Buddhist diets, commonly garlic, onions, leeks, chives, and asafoetida or a related allium.
Five Realms	Heavenly beings, humans, animals, hungry ghosts, and hell beings. A Six Realms scheme counts asuras separately instead of grouping them with another realm.
Five signs of decay	Signs that a deva’s long heavenly life is ending, traditionally including fading adornments, wilting flowers, bodily changes, and loss of ease on the celestial seat.
Five Stages of Misconceptions	Five layers or “dwelling places” of delusion, from wrong views and desire-realm attachments through subtler attachments in higher realms to fundamental ignorance.
Five Types and Seven Categories of Vinaya Violations	Two technical ways of classifying monastic offenses by their kind and seriousness. The exact categories depend on the Vinaya system, and the PDF does not enumerate them.
Five Views	Belief in a permanent self, extreme views such as eternalism or annihilationism, denial of moral causation, treating one’s own wrong view as supreme, and clinging to rites as sufficient for liberation.
Five Wisdoms	Five dimensions of awakened knowing: the wisdom of reality itself, mirror-like wisdom, equality, discerning wisdom, and all-accomplishing wisdom.
Five worldly teachings; five worldly dharmas	The PDF contrasts these with the Noble Eightfold Path. A traditional commentary identifies the five as conventional names, conventional sentences, the five aggregates, the eighteen realms of experience, and the twenty-five modes of conditioned existence. The point is that analyzing ordinary conventions is not the same as following the path to liberation.
Flowers of transgression; causing them to wilt	A ritual metaphor: harmful actions are imagined as flowers that wither when their causes are confessed and abandoned.
Flying zombies; hundred monsters; evil ghosts	Premodern terms for feared supernatural beings, omens, or calamity-bringing forces. The PDF offers no taxonomy, and a modern reader need not treat them as medical explanations.
Form is emptiness; emptiness is form	The Heart Sūtra’s statement that physical and mental phenomena function conventionally but have no fixed, independent essence. Emptiness is not a separate substance behind form.
Four Attachments	Four rigid positions about phenomena: that all things are one, are different, are both one and different, or are neither. The point is that turning any of these conceptual positions into an absolute view becomes an obstruction.
Four Attachments or Stations of Consciousness	Four ways consciousness is described as settling on form, sensation, perception, and volitional formations.
Four Bindings; Four Shackles	Desire, anger, clinging to ineffective rites, and belief in a permanent self – forces said to tie beings to suffering.
Four Conditions	Four broad kinds of causal support: a direct cause, the immediately preceding condition, an object of attention, and other enabling conditions.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Four Desires; Four Cravings	Attachment to the four material requisites traditionally used by monastics: clothing, food, lodging, and medicine. The fault is compulsive attachment, not the practical use of necessities.
Four Dhyānas	Four progressively refined states of meditative absorption, moving from joyful collectedness to deep equanimity and stillness.
Four Elements	Earth or solidity, water or cohesion, fire or temperature, and wind or movement – the traditional analysis of physical matter and the body.
Four Elements as venomous snakes; Five Aggregates as bandits; Six Senses as an empty formation	Strong cautionary metaphors. They say that clinging to body and mind can betray or endanger us; they do not mean that the body, senses, or every experience is morally evil.
Four Emptinesses; four formless concentrations	Concentrations on infinite space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, and neither perception nor non-perception. “Emptinesses” here means formless meditative attainments, not four separate definitions of emptiness.
Four Faiths	Stable trust in the Buddha, Dharma, Sangha, and ethical conduct.
Four Forms of Birth; Four Forms of Existence	Traditional modes of rebirth: birth from a womb, from an egg, from moisture, or by spontaneous transformation.
Four Fruitions and Four Progressions	Four levels of early Buddhist awakening – stream-enterer, once-returner, non-returner, and arhat – each considered as the path toward it and the attainment of its result.
Four graspings	Clinging to sensual pleasure, views, rites and rules as ends in themselves, and a doctrine of a permanent self.
Four kindnesses	Great debts of gratitude, commonly understood in East Asian Buddhism as owed to parents, sentient beings, society or rulers, and the Triple Gem. Lists can vary.
Four Kinds of Fearlessness	A Buddha’s confidence in teaching: complete awakening, ending the outflows, identifying obstacles, and showing the path that ends suffering.
Four Kinds of Observation	The four reflections stated in Scroll Two: examine causes and conditions, karmic results, one’s own conditioned body, and the awakened qualities of a Buddha.
Four Kinds of Offering	The basic material supports offered to monastics: food, clothing, lodging or bedding, and medicine.
Four Lemmas	A four-way test of a claim: it is, is not, both is and is not, or neither is nor is not. It is used to expose the limits of rigid conceptual positions.
Four Limitless or Immeasurable Minds	Loving-kindness, compassion, appreciative joy, and equanimity extended without limit to all beings.
Four Lower Realms	Hells, hungry ghosts, animals, and asuras. Some passages instead say “Three Lower Realms,” omitting asuras as a separate lower category.
Four Major and Eight Major Offenses	Serious violations in particular monastic and lay-bodhisattva precept systems. The exact list depends on which precept code is meant, and the PDF does not identify the code.
Four Means of Embracing	Four ways a bodhisattva draws people toward well-being and the Dharma: generosity, kind speech, helpful action, and cooperation or empathy.
Four Noble Truths	The truth of suffering or dissatisfaction, its origin in craving and ignorance, its cessation, and the path leading to that cessation.
Four postures	Walking, standing, sitting, and lying down – the ordinary bodily positions in which mindfulness and non-harming are to be practiced.
Four Shared Traits	An unusual English rendering of the Chinese “four equal or immeasurable [attitudes].” In this passage it most naturally points to loving-kindness, compassion, appreciative joy, and equanimity extended impartially to all beings.
Four Torrents; Four Flows	Desire, continued existence, wrong views, and ignorance, pictured as strong currents carrying beings through saṃsāra.
Four Universal Vows	To save limitless beings, end limitless afflictions, learn limitless Dharma teachings, and attain unsurpassed Buddhahood.
Four Unobstructed Wisdoms	Unhindered understanding of meaning, teachings, language or expression, and confident explanation.
Fourfold training lists within the Thirty-Seven Factors	The Four Foundations of Mindfulness, Four Proper Exertions, and Four Bases or Means of Accomplishment: practices for mindful observation, wholesome effort, and focused spiritual power.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Friends and foes as equal; friends and foes benefit together	Impartial compassion: wishing liberation for those one likes and those with whom one has conflict. It does not require ignoring present danger or abandoning wise boundaries.
Front or back orifice	Blunt wording in a celibacy passage for sexual penetration involving the genitals or anus. It is describing violations of monastic “pure conduct,” not introducing a separate meditation term.
Fruits; fruitions; results and effects	The outcomes of causes, especially the pleasant or painful results attributed to intentional karma and spiritual practice.
Ganges sands; grains of dust	Stock images for a number so vast that it is effectively beyond counting.
Gate of Sweet Dew	A poetic name for liberating Buddhist teaching. Sweet dew or nectar represents the “deathless” relief of nirvāṇa.
Golden Sage; King of Awakening; Tamer	Honorific images for a Buddha: radiant with wisdom, sovereign in awakening, and able to guide difficult beings.
Heart Sūtra	A short and influential Mahāyāna scripture teaching the emptiness of the five aggregates and all fixed categories, while presenting wisdom beyond attachment as the way through suffering.
Heart Sūtra’s “no eyes … no path … no attainment”	Speech from the ultimate perspective of emptiness: none of these categories exists independently or can be possessed as a fixed thing. It is not a denial that eyes, ethical practice, or the path function in everyday life.
Heavenly or celestial eyes	A traditional supernormal ability to see far away, through obstructions, and into beings’ karmic destinies. It is also used figuratively for vision beyond ordinary sight.
Hell wardens; Ox-Headed Warden	Fearsome figures in Buddhist hell narratives who administer karmic punishment. They personify the unavoidable consequences described by the text.
Homage	A respectful salutation expressing reverence, gratitude, and willingness to learn.
Honored Kanaka	The saintly monk in the Water Repentance origin story who directs Wuda to the samādhi spring. He is traditionally identified with the arhat Kanakavatsa.
Hundred and One Essential Items	A traditional general expression for the many ordinary necessities of daily life, not necessarily a literal checklist of exactly 101 objects here.
Hundred Disagreements	A stock phrase for the many speculative positions produced by combining conceptual claims. “Ending” them means going beyond fruitless argument, not merely winning a debate.
Hungry ghost	A being in a painful realm characterized by extreme, unsatisfied hunger and thirst; a symbol and cosmological result of consuming greed and stinginess.
Icchantika	A person described in some Mahāyāna texts as having cut off or rejected the roots of goodness and the wish for awakening. Later traditions debate whether anyone is permanently incapable of Buddhahood.
Ignorance	Not merely lack of information, but a basic misperception of reality – especially taking impermanent, conditioned experience to be a fixed self or lasting source of satisfaction.
Imperial and dynastic references: Western Han, Tang, Song, and Yongle reign	Historical markers locating the origin legend and its later transmission in Chinese history. They are not Buddhist stages or realms.
Impermanence	The fact that all conditioned things change and do not remain under complete control.
Incense Cloud Canopy	A ritual image in which incense smoke becomes a vast, protective offering above the assembly. It is also the title of the bodhisattvas invoked in that praise.
Inherent nature	A fixed, independent essence that something would possess by itself. The text says transgressions lack such a nature because they arise and cease through conditions.
Inverted views; inverted dream-like delusions	Seeing reality backwards – for example, treating the impermanent as permanent, suffering as lasting happiness, the non-self as a self, or the impure as pure.
Jambudvīpa; Jambudvīpan lifespan	In ancient Buddhist cosmology, the southern continent around Mount Meru, understood as the human world in which we live.
Join the palms	Place the hands together at the chest as a gesture of respect and collected attention.
Kalaviṅka	A mythical bird celebrated for an extraordinarily beautiful voice; the Buddha’s speech is compared to its song.
Kalpa	An immensely long cosmic period. Phrases such as “kalpas as numerous as dust” mean an inconceivably long time.
Kāmalā disease	An old medical term generally associated with jaundice. In the origin story it afflicts the sick monk whom Zhixuan compassionately nurses; it is separate from Wuda’s later human-faced tumor.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Karma and consciousness are suddenly empty	A realization that karma and consciousness lack a permanent independent essence. It does not mean that ethical consequences are casually cancelled or that awareness becomes literal nothingness.
Karma; karmic action	Intentional action of body, speech, or mind and the causal pattern it creates. Karma is not simply fate, punishment, or everything that happens.
Karmic conditions	Circumstances shaped in part by earlier intentional actions and interacting present causes.
Karmic obstacles; karmic obstructions	Effects of past or present actions that make ethical conduct, meditation, understanding, or favorable circumstances harder.
Karmic retribution; residual retribution	The maturing result of intentional action. “Residual” retribution means effects that remain even after the main karmic result has been experienced.
Kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity	The Four Limitless Minds: wishing happiness, wishing freedom from suffering, rejoicing in others’ good, and caring impartially.
King Yāma	The judge of the dead in Buddhist cosmology, who examines actions and assigns hell consequences. He is not an all-powerful creator or eternal devil.
Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva	“Earth Treasury,” the bodhisattva especially associated in East Asian Buddhism with rescuing beings in hell and caring for the deceased.
Kumbhāṇḍa	A class of misshapen, potentially harmful spirit in Indian and Buddhist cosmology.
Last meal offered to a Buddha entering nirvāṇa	An allusion to the honored final meal offered to Śākyamuni before his death and final nirvāṇa. The vow means wishing always to have the rare opportunity to support a Buddha.
Liberation; other shore	Freedom from affliction, suffering, and the cycle of rebirth. Crossing an ocean or reaching the “other shore” is a common metaphor for attaining it.
Liturgy	A fixed order of communal worship, chanting, movement, confession, and dedication.
Lotus birth; born through transformation	Rebirth in a Pure Land pictured as appearing within a lotus rather than being born through an ordinary womb.
Lotus Pool or Great Oceanic Assembly	The vast gathering of Amitābha, bodhisattvas, and Pure Land practitioners, poetically pictured around a lotus pool.
Loving-kindness	The sincere wish that beings be happy and encounter the causes of happiness.
Mahāsthāmaprāpta Bodhisattva	The bodhisattva “Arrival of Great Strength,” representing the power of wisdom and mindful recollection of Amitābha in Pure Land Buddhism.
Mahāvyūha Bodhisattva	A bodhisattva invoked in the repeated litany. The English text supplies no narrative; the name can be understood as “Great Adornment” or “Great Array.”
Mahāyāna; Great Vehicle	A broad Buddhist tradition centred on the bodhisattva path and full Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings. Chinese Buddhism, including this liturgy, is Mahāyāna.
Maitreya Buddha	The future Buddha expected to awaken and teach in this world after Śākyamuni’s dispensation has disappeared. His name is connected with loving-kindness.
Manifested Buddha or bodhisattva; trillion-fold bodies; thirty-two responses	Different forms that an awakened being is said to display according to beings’ needs. The numbers emphasize limitless compassionate adaptability.
Mañjuśrī Bodhisattva	The bodhisattva who personifies profound wisdom. He is often shown with a sword that cuts through ignorance.
Mantra	A sacred formula recited for concentration, protection, purification, or blessing. The sound may be preserved even when a straightforward word-for-word translation is unavailable.
Marks and characteristics; Thirty-Two Marks and Eighty Signs; ūrṇā	Idealized bodily features said to display a Buddha’s accumulated virtue. The ūrṇā is the white curl or mark between the eyebrows, sometimes poetically called jade.
Master Wuda Zhixuan	The eminent Chinese monk to whom the Water Repentance is attributed. In the origin legend, a painful human-faced tumor reveals an old karmic grievance and is cleansed with samādhi water.
Medicine Master Buddha	The Buddha associated with healing, protection from disaster, and the aspiration for long and wholesome life.
Memorial Altar Dedication	A ritual section directing merit toward people who have died and aspiring for their peaceful rebirth, especially in Amitābha’s Pure Land.
Merit and virtue; blessings	Beneficial spiritual qualities and results cultivated through ethical action, generosity, meditation, wisdom, and ritual. “Merit” is not a commercial credit that can simply purchase salvation.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Middle Way	Avoiding the extremes of self-indulgence and self-torment and, philosophically, avoiding rigid claims of absolute existence or absolute nonexistence.
Mind consciousness; mind organ	The mental faculty that notices ideas, memories, emotions, and other mental objects, treated in Buddhism as a sixth sense alongside the five physical senses.
Mind's eye; wisdom life; wisdom root	Metaphors for the capacity to understand the Dharma. Afflictions "blind the mind's eye" or "cut the wisdom root" when they undermine that capacity.
Mount Meru; Four Continents	The central mountain and surrounding human worlds in ancient Buddhist cosmology. They provide the traditional map used in many scriptures and rituals.
Mt. Jiulong; Nine Peaks; Western Shu; Pengzhou	Place names in the Wuda origin story, describing the mountain region where he seeks Honored Kanaka and finds the healing spring.
Nāga	A powerful serpent or dragon-like being associated with water, treasure, and protection of the Dharma.
National Master	An honorific given by an emperor to an eminent Buddhist teacher who served or advised the state.
Nine Conditions	The Chinese term can refer to nine supports by which sensory consciousness arises, such as a functioning faculty, an object, light or space, attention, and continuity. Commentators on this exact repentance passage disagree about whether that technical list is intended, so the safest beginner meaning is "the many conditions through which confused consciousness and action arise."
Nine Difficulties; Nine Vexations	The PDF's "Difficulties" translates a term for nine occasions of resentment: thinking that someone harmed, harms, or will harm oneself; did so to someone one loves; or helped, helps, or will help someone one opposes. It shows anger multiplying across self/other and past/present/future.
Nine Empty Concentrations	A sequence of deep meditations, usually the Four Dhyānas, four formless attainments, and cessation. "Empty" here does not mean blank unconsciousness at every stage.
Nine Fetters	A list of bonds such as craving, anger, pride, ignorance, wrong views, clinging, doubt, envy, and stinginess that keep beings tied to saṃsāra.
Nine grades or stages of lotus blossoms	Nine traditional levels of rebirth in Amitābha's Pure Land, reflecting different degrees of faith, practice, and realization.
Nine obscurities covering the land	A poetic or cosmological image for widespread darkness dispelled by the Buddha's teaching. The English text does not identify nine individual obscurities.
Nine Orifices	The body's nine openings: two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, mouth, urinary opening, and anus. The contemplation emphasizes the body's physical, non-idealized nature.
Nine Severing Wisdoms; Nine Knowledges of Abandonment	An Abhidharma analysis of nine completed acts of abandoning groups of afflictions as insight penetrates the Four Noble Truths across the desire, form, and formless realms. "Wisdom" here means verified liberating knowledge that a particular bondage has been cut off, not nine clever ideas.
Ninety-Eight Afflictions; One Hundred and Eight Afflictions	Traditional comprehensive counts of defilements, produced by classifying basic afflictions across realms and stages of practice. "108 afflictions" is also a common symbolic total for the many ways the mind becomes troubled.
Nirvāṇa	Liberation in which greed, hatred, ignorance, and the causes of rebirth have been extinguished. It is not simply a heavenly place.
Noble Eightfold Path	Right view, intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness, and concentration – the practical path leading to the end of suffering.
Non-arising; state or patience of non-arising	Insight that phenomena do not arise as independent, permanent things. "Patience" here means a stable, unshaken acceptance of that realization.
Non-retrogressing bodhisattva	A bodhisattva who has reached a stage from which progress toward Buddhahood will no longer fall back.
Non-self	The teaching that no permanent, independent, fully controlling "I" can be found in the changing body and mind. It does not deny ordinary personhood or ethical responsibility.
Noon Offering Before the Buddhas	A midday food-offering service addressed to Buddhas, bodhisattvas, the Sangha, and – in expanded dedication – all beings.
Ocean of the Flower Treasury; Lotus Treasury	Vast, interpenetrating Buddha-realms associated especially with Vairocana and the Flower Adornment Sūtra. In the liturgy they evoke the cosmic scope of awakening.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
One Reality	The single, undivided truth of things as they are, beyond the fragmented way ignorance ordinarily perceives them.
One Vehicle	The Mahāyāna teaching that the Buddha's various paths ultimately lead toward the one complete awakening of Buddhahood.
One-child mind of compassion	Caring for every sentient being with the urgency and tenderness a loving parent gives an only child.
Outflow	A deep mental taint or "leak," such as craving or ignorance, that continually feeds suffering and rebirth.
Ox-Headed Warden, flaming pills, sword wheels, and other hell imagery	Deliberately shocking images of karmic suffering. They function as moral warning and cosmological description within the liturgy, not as instructions for human punishment.
Pāramitā; perfection; other shore of pāramitā	A virtue developed to the level that carries a bodhisattva to awakening. Pāramitā is traditionally associated with "reaching the other shore."
Past Seven Buddhas: Vipaśyin, Śikhin, Viśvabhū, Krakucchanda, Kanakamuni, Kāśyapa, and Śākyamuni	A traditional succession of six Buddhas before Śākyamuni, followed by Śākyamuni as the seventh. They are invoked as witnesses and sources of the Dharma.
Patience of equality	Patient stability based on seeing beings and phenomena without rigid discrimination or favoritism. It does not mean passively accepting abuse.
Perfect Awakening, Wondrous Awakening, and Equal Awakening Stage Bodhisattvas	Titles for extremely advanced stages near Buddhahood in East Asian Mahāyāna systems. The ritual addresses all bodhisattvas at those levels collectively.
Permanence, bliss, self-nature, and purity	In Mahāyāna language, four positive qualities of complete nirvāṇa. "Self" or "self-nature" here points to freedom from the false ego and from change-driven suffering, not to an ordinary eternal personal soul.
Pillars and crossbeams of the Buddhadharma	A building metaphor for people who strongly support, preserve, and transmit Buddhist teaching and community.
Prabhūtaratna Buddha	"Many Treasures Buddha," who appears with his jeweled stūpa in the Lotus Sūtra to witness and affirm its teaching.
Prajñā	Deep wisdom that directly understands reality, especially impermanence, non-self, dependent arising, and emptiness.
Prajñāpāramitā; Mahāprajñāpāramitā	The "perfection of wisdom," the insight into emptiness that guides the bodhisattva path. "Mahā" means great.
Pratyekabuddha	A "solitary Buddha" who awakens to dependent origination without a Buddha teaching in the world, but does not establish a broad teaching dispensation.
Precepts	Ethical training commitments intended to prevent harm and support clarity, concentration, and compassion.
Proper Dharma; honored Dharma	Respectful terms for teachings considered authentic and conducive to awakening. "Proper" contrasts with distorted teaching, not with ordinary etiquette.
Proper sensation	The preface's unusual English gloss for samādhi. In context it means an undistracted, rightly settled awareness, close to "proper concentration," not a particular physical sensation.
Prophecy or prediction of awakening	A Buddha's assurance that a practitioner will attain Buddhahood in the future, often including the future Buddha's name or realm.
Prostration; "touch our heads to the floor"	A full bow expressing humility, reverence, and the letting go of pride. Three prostrations are a common ritual set.
Pure Land; Western Pure Land; Realm of Ultimate Bliss	A realm established through Amitābha Buddha's vows where conditions strongly support progress toward awakening.
Pure precepts; precepts, concentration, and wisdom	Ethical discipline purified of intentional violation, together with meditative stability and insight – the three core trainings of Buddhist practice.
Rājagṛha; Mount Vipula	Rājagṛha, present-day Rajgir in India, was an important city during the Buddha's life. Nearby Mount Vipula is used in the text's vast comparison of bones accumulated through rebirth.
Rākṣasa	An ogre-like, often flesh-eating spirit in Buddhist stories. "Rākṣasas of Affliction" personifies destructive mental states as predators.
Rebirth in borderlands; three evils	"Borderlands" is an old Buddhist term for places where the Dharma was believed unavailable; it should not be read as a modern judgment of ethnic worth. "Three evils" here most likely means the three lower realms.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Rebirth in future lives	The continuation of conditioned existence after death through karmic causation. Buddhism generally does not explain it as an unchanged soul moving from body to body.
Refuge; Three Refuges; “return our lives in refuge”	Entrusting one’s life and direction to the Buddha as teacher, the Dharma as path, and the Sangha as community. “Return our lives” is a literal, devotional way of saying “take wholehearted refuge.”
Remorse and shame	Healthy recognition of harm: remorse looks honestly at one’s own action, while moral shame includes concern for integrity and the effect on others. The aim is reform, not permanent self-hatred.
Repentance and reform	Acknowledging harmful actions, regretting them, making amends where possible, and resolving not to repeat them. The added word “reform” stresses changed conduct, not confession alone.
Resultative obstruction	Painful circumstances or rebirths understood as matured karmic results that obstruct practice. It is the third of the Three Obstructions.
Retributive body	The present body viewed as a result of past karma and as subject to ageing, illness, and death.
Ritual collective bodhisattva titles: Incense Cloud Canopy, Precious Uḍumbara Blossom, Universal Offering, Pure Cool Ground, Dhyāna Bliss Treasury, and Ascending the Path of Clouds	Devotional names addressing groups of bodhisattvas associated with the particular praise, offering, dedication, or closing action. They need not each be read as the biography of one separately identified historical person.
Sacred and ordinary beings	“Sacred” means awakened or highly realized beings; “ordinary” means those still governed by ignorance and affliction.
Śakra; Emperor Śakra; Lord of the Devas	The ruler of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three in Buddhist cosmology. He supports the Dharma but remains a conditioned, impermanent celestial being.
Śākyamuni Buddha; our teacher	The historical Buddha of our world, Siddhārtha Gautama, who awakened in India and taught the path followed in Buddhism.
Samādhi	Deep meditative collectedness in which the mind is stable, clear, and not scattered by ordinary reactions.
Samādhi water; Dharma water	In the origin story, spring water blessed by meditative and spiritual power; more broadly, a metaphor for the Dharma cleansing hatred, guilt, and karmic obstruction.
Samantabhadra Bodhisattva; King of Vows; Honored Universal Auspiciousness	The bodhisattva who represents great practice and vows, especially homage, offering, repentance, learning, helping beings, and dedicating merit.
Saṃsāra; cycle or wheel of birth and death; transmigration	Repeated conditioned birth and death driven by ignorance, craving, and karma.
Sanctuary of Awakening; repentance sanctuary; repentance altar	The consecrated ritual space and the practice performed there. “Sanctuary” can refer both to the physical hall or altar and to the full repentance ceremony.
Sangha	Most specifically, the ordained Buddhist community; as the third of the Triple Gem, it can also mean the noble community that has realized the teaching.
Sanghārāma; Sanghārāma Bodhisattvas	A monastery or monastic precinct; in East Asian ritual, “Sanghārāma Bodhisattvas” are guardian figures who protect monasteries and their communities.
Śāriputra	One of Śākyamuni Buddha’s leading disciples, renowned for wisdom. The Heart Sūtra addresses its explanation of emptiness to him.
Sarvajña; omniscience	Literally “all-knowing.” In this context it means a Buddha’s complete liberating knowledge of phenomena and the ways to guide beings.
Śāstra	A systematic Buddhist treatise or commentary that explains and analyzes teachings.
Scroll	One major division or volume of the liturgy. The three PDFs correspond to the upper, middle, and lower scrolls.
Secret verses	Mantras or dhāraṇīs recited in their traditional sounds. “Secret” suggests esoteric or spiritually potent language, not a hidden conspiracy.
Self-nature	Depending on context, either the mistakenly imagined fixed essence of a person or the deeper awakened nature spoken of in Mahāyāna. It should not be assumed to mean an eternal personal soul.
Sending-Off the Sacred	A closing ritual praise that respectfully concludes the presence or attention of the Buddhas, bodhisattvas, and protectors invoked during the service.
Sentient being	Any being capable of conscious experience and suffering. In Buddhist cosmology this includes humans, animals, devas, ghosts, and hell beings.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Seven Buddhas Offense-Extinguishing Mantra	A purification chant recited at the end of each scroll. The title states its ritual purpose; the syllables themselves are preserved as a phonetic sacred formula.
Seven Expedient Means	Seven preparatory stages toward direct insight: three broad stages of worthiness followed by Warmth, Summit, Acceptance, and Supreme Attribute.
Seven Factors or Limbs of Awakening	Mindfulness, investigation, energy, joy, tranquility, concentration, and equanimity – qualities cultivated together as awakening develops.
Seven Kinds of Mind	The seven attitudes listed in Scroll One: remorse and shame, fear of consequences, dispassion, bodhi mind, equality toward friends and foes, gratitude for the Buddha's kindness, and understanding the empty nature of transgressions.
Seven limbs of complete precepts	The seven bodily and verbal branches of ethical conduct: not killing, stealing, or engageing in sexual misconduct, and not using false, divisive, harsh, or frivolous speech. They are the first seven of the Ten Wholesome Deeds; the remaining three concern the mind.
Seven Outflows	A technical list concerning ways defilements continue to "leak" through unguarded living and ways they are abandoned. The PDF names the group but does not give its seven members.
Seven Purities; Lotus of Seven Purities	Seven linked purifications: ethical conduct, mind, view, overcoming doubt, knowing what is and is not the path, knowing the course of practice, and liberating knowledge that severs defilement. The lotus is a poetic image for these purities unfolding through practice.
Seven Tendencies	Latent inclinations toward sensual desire, aversion, views, doubt, conceit, craving for continued existence, and ignorance.
Seven Treasures	A conventional set of precious materials, often including gold, silver, crystal, beryl, coral or pearl, and other gems; the exact list varies.
Six Consciousnesses	Visual, auditory, olfactory, taste, touch, and mental consciousness arising when a sense organ meets its object.
Six Dusts; six sense objects	Sights, sounds, smells, tastes, tangible objects, and mental objects. "Dusts" suggests that attachment to them can cloud the mind; the objects are not inherently evil.
Six Emotions; Six Perceptions; Six Sensations; Six Volitions; Six Passions; Six Doubts	Several sixfold analyses of how experience is noticed, felt, interpreted, intended, craved, or doubted through the six senses. The PDF names these technical groups without listing each set.
Six Faculties; six sense organs; six senses	Eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind – the six capacities through which experience occurs. Each has its object and consciousness: eye–forms–visual consciousness, ear–sounds–auditory consciousness, nose–odours–olfactory consciousness, tongue–tastes–taste consciousness, body–tangible objects–tactile consciousness, and mind–mental objects–mental consciousness.
Six fasting days; three long fasting periods	Traditional lay observance times for stricter precepts, vegetarian practice, repentance, and merit-making: six days each lunar month and three longer periods during the year. Calendrical details vary.
Six Pāramitās; Six Perfections	Generosity, ethical discipline, patience, diligent effort, meditative concentration, and wisdom, cultivated for the benefit of all beings.
Six points of reverent harmony	Communal harmony in bodily conduct, speech, thought, ethical discipline, understanding, and fair sharing of material support.
Six recollections	Recollecting the Buddha, Dharma, Sangha, ethical conduct, generosity, and devas or the wholesome qualities represented by them.
Six Spiritual Powers	Traditional abilities arising from advanced practice: extraordinary movement or manifestation, heavenly sight, heavenly hearing, reading minds, recalling past lives, and knowing the ending of the outflows.
Six types of kin	A general traditional expression for one's close family relations. Exact enumerations vary; in this liturgy it means the wider family, not six named supernatural beings.
Six Wondrous Gates	A meditation sequence usually explained as counting the breath, following it, stabilizing the mind, observing, turning awareness back, and purification.
Sixteen improper livelihoods	An ancient list of occupations organized around harm. It includes raising or buying animals for slaughter, fishing, hunting and trapping, robbery, execution or punitive confinement, malicious divisive speech, and coercive control of animals. The underlying principle is to avoid work built on killing, cruelty, exploitation, or deliberate harm.
Sixteen Understandings and Views	Sixteen aspects of insight into the Four Noble Truths – four ways of understanding each truth.
Sixty-Two Views	A traditional catalogue of speculative theories about self and world, especially eternalist and annihilationist positions, treated as traps of attachment.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Spiritual response; efficacious	A perceived sign that sincere practice has met with the compassionate activity of Buddhas or bodhisattvas. “Efficacious” means believed to produce a real religious effect.
Śramaṇa	A renunciant spiritual practitioner; in this Buddhist text it usually means a monk or nun.
Śrāvaka	Literally a “hearer”: a disciple who reaches liberation by hearing and practicing a Buddha’s teaching. Mahāyāna texts contrast this goal with the bodhisattva’s aim of full Buddhahood.
Śrotāpanna; stream-enterer	The first of four stages of arhat awakening, at which a practitioner has entered the irreversible stream toward liberation.
Stūpa	A sacred mound or monument that enshrines relics, scriptures, or associations with a Buddha or other revered teacher.
Suffering; dissatisfaction	Renderings of duḥkha: obvious pain as well as the deeper unreliability and inability of conditioned life to provide permanent satisfaction.
Supreme caste	Traditional Indian social-ranking language used in the Pure Land vow. In context it expresses a wish for an honored and unobstructed rebirth in Amitābha Buddha’s land.
Sūtra	A scripture or discourse presenting Buddhist teaching, traditionally connected with the Buddha’s words.
Sweet dew; ambrosia	A symbol of the “deathless” freedom of nirvāṇa and the refreshing, life-giving quality of the Dharma.
Tathāgata	“Thus Come One” or “Thus Gone One,” a title a Buddha uses for one who has fully realized reality.
Tathāgata’s robes; armor of patience; bed of fearlessness; seat of empty phenomena; food of Dharma joy	Poetic images for living within the Buddha’s teaching, being protected by patient endurance, being free from fear, being grounded in emptiness, and being inwardly nourished by the Dharma.
Ten Afflictions	Commonly greed, anger, ignorance, pride, doubt, belief in a self, extreme views, denial of causality, attachment to wrong views, and attachment to rites as sufficient.
Ten Bonds; Ten Ensnaring Afflictions	Ten states that wrap around or entangle the mind: lack of inner shame, lack of concern about wrongdoing before others, envy, stinginess, agitated remorse, drowsiness, restlessness, mental dullness, rage, and concealment of one’s faults.
Ten Dedications	Ten stages on the bodhisattva path in which cultivated goodness is turned toward all beings and full awakening.
Ten Directions	North, south, east, west, the four intermediate directions, above, and below – a ritual way of saying everywhere.
Ten Illuminations	Ten forms of far-reaching bodhisattva knowledge in the Flower Adornment Sūtra, including knowledge of other minds, karmic continuity and rebirth, past and future, languages and meanings, and the nature of phenomena. They express unobstructed wisdom rather than literal lamps.
Ten Pāramitās	The Six Perfections plus skillful means, vows, spiritual power, and knowledge.
Ten Powers	Ten forms of a Buddha’s complete knowledge, including causes and effects, karmic results, beings’ capacities, meditative paths, past lives, rebirths, and liberation.
Ten Practices	Ten stages of compassionate bodhisattva conduct within the traditional fifty-two-stage path, following the Ten Abodes and preceding the Ten Dedications.
Ten Unwholesome Deeds or Karmas	Killing, stealing, sexual misconduct; false, divisive, harsh, and frivolous speech; greed, ill will, and wrong views.
Ten Vows	In this liturgy the phrase generally points to Samantabhadra’s great vows: homage, praise, offering, repentance, rejoicing, requesting teaching, asking Buddhas to remain, learning, helping beings, and dedicating merit.
Ten Wisdoms	Ten analytical and liberating knowledges, including understanding Dharma, comparison, conventional life, others’ minds, each Noble Truth, the ending of outflows, and non-arising.
The Thirty-Seven Factors of Awakening	A combined framework of Four Foundations of Mindfulness, Four Proper Exertions, Four Bases of Accomplishment, Five Faculties, Five Powers, Seven Factors of Awakening, and the Noble Eightfold Path.
The Three Thousand Etiquettes; Eighty Thousand Regulations	Large conventional numbers for the detailed rules of mindful monastic conduct. They stress care in everyday behaviour rather than requiring a beginner to locate 83,000 separate rules.
Thirty-six parts of the body	A contemplation listing bodily materials and organs to counter idealization, sensual attachment, and belief that the body is a pure, permanent self.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Three assemblies under the Dragon Blossom Tree	Three future gatherings at which Maitreya Buddha is expected to teach and liberate vast numbers of beings after awakening beneath the Dragon Blossom Tree.
Three Awakenings	Self-awakening, helping others awaken, and the complete perfection of both awakening and conduct. The triad describes the full accomplishment of a Buddha.
Three Bodies	The Dharma body as ultimate reality, the reward or enjoyment body experienced by advanced bodhisattvas, and manifested bodies that appear in worlds to teach.
Three Contemplations	Contemplating emptiness, provisional or conditioned existence, and the Middle Way that holds both without clinging to either extreme.
Three Delusions	In an East Asian Mahāyāna framework: delusions of views and desires, the innumerable misunderstandings that obstruct helping beings, and fundamental ignorance about reality.
Three Insights; Three Understandings	Knowledge of past lives, knowledge of beings' deaths and rebirths, and knowledge that one's own outflows have ended. The two English labels appear to point to this same traditional triad.
Three Karmas	Intentional action through body, speech, and mind. "Purifying the three karmas" means bringing all three into ethical and mindful alignment.
Three kinds of light	Sunlight, moonlight, and starlight. The hell passage imagines a darkness in which none of these three natural lights can be recognized.
Three Lower Realms	The animal, hungry ghost, and hell realms, regarded as especially painful rebirths.
Three minds	In the immediate context, most likely the mind as obscured by greed, anger, and ignorance, since those three afflictions are named in the lines that follow. The source uses a compressed poetic label rather than a formal enumeration.
Three Obstructions	Afflictive obstruction in the mind, karmic obstruction created by action, and resultative obstruction when painful consequences mature.
Three Outflows	Deep taints associated with sensual craving, craving for continued existence, and ignorance, which keep experience "flowing out" into rebirth.
Three Periods; three time periods	Past, present, and future. "Buddhas of the three periods" means Buddhas of all times.
Three Poisons	Greed, anger or hatred, and ignorance – the three basic causes of harmful action and suffering.
Three Realms	The desire realm, form realm, and formless realm – the full range of conditioned rebirth in this cosmology.
Three Samādhis	Three liberating concentrations: emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness or aimlessness.
Three Sufferings	Painful suffering, suffering caused by change, and the pervasive unsatisfactoriness of all conditioned existence.
Three timings of karmic retribution	Results may mature in the present life, the next life, or a more distant future life. The passage uses this to explain why present fortune does not always match present conduct.
Three turnings of the Dharma wheel; third turning	A way of grouping the Buddha's teachings into three major cycles or emphases. In the closing ritual, "third turning" also resonates with completing the third scroll and session.
Three Unstained Learnings	Ethical discipline, meditative concentration, and wisdom practiced free of the "outflows" that perpetuate rebirth.
Three Vehicles	Paths associated with the śrāvaka, pratyekabuddha, and bodhisattva. Mahāyāna texts often teach that these are ultimately gathered into the One Vehicle.
Three virtues and six flavors of food	A traditional ideal offering: food is clean, gentle or wholesome, and prepared in accordance with the Dharma, with the six tastes of bitter, sour, sweet, hot or pungent, salty, and mild.
Three Vows	A named set of aspirations in Scroll One. The English text does not identify the three, and several different Buddhist triads are called "Three Vows."
Three Wisdoms	Wisdom that knows general reality, wisdom that knows the different paths and needs of beings, and a Buddha's complete knowledge of all aspects.
Transformation of Food, Sweet Dew, and Universal Offering Dhāraṇīs	Offering chants understood respectively to multiply or transform food, purify it into liberating nectar, and extend the offering universally to sacred beings and beings in every realm.
Trichiliocosm; three-thousandfold world system	A vast traditional Buddhist cosmos containing an enormous number of worlds. It does not mean only three thousand planets.
Triple Gem	The Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha: the awakened teacher, the teaching and path, and the community that preserves and realizes it.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Triple Invocation	Calling a sacred name three times to begin or focus a ritual section.
True Thusness; One Truth; true nature of reality	Reality as it is before it is distorted by craving, aversion, and fixed concepts. Also called suchness.
Twelve Contacts; Twelve Sense Bases; Twelve Elements	The PDF's "Twelve Contacts" translates the twelve entrances or bases: the six faculties – eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind – plus their six objects – forms, sounds, odours, tastes, tangible objects, and mental objects. Their meeting provides the conditions for the corresponding consciousness.
Twelve Links of Dependent Origination	Ignorance, formations, consciousness, name-and-form, six sense bases, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, and ageing-and-death – the cycle explaining how suffering continues.
Twelve-aspect Dharma Wheel	The Four Noble Truths each understood in three phases: recognising the truth, knowing the task it requires, and knowing that the task has been completed.
Twenty-Five Aspects of Self	A technical catalogue of ways a person can mistakenly identify a permanent self with body and mind. The English text gives the total but not the twenty-five individual views.
Two kinds of inverted views	Most likely distorted perception and distorted belief: first experiencing or imagining a sense object in a confused way, then forming and defending an incorrect view about it. Both make what is unstable and conditioned appear fixed or self-sufficient.
Two obstructions	Afflictive obstruction, which binds beings to suffering, and cognitive obstruction, which prevents complete knowledge and Buddhahood.
Two Truths	Conventional truth – how things function in everyday dependent reality – and ultimate truth – their emptiness of fixed, independent essence.
Udrakarāmaputra; state of neither thinking nor not-thinking	Udrakarāmaputra is the teacher called Uddaka Rāmaputta in many English sources. The state is the highest of the four formless concentrations, subtle but still within saṃsāra.
Uḍumbara blossom	A legendary flower said to appear extremely rarely, used as an image for the rare appearance of a Buddha or other auspicious event.
Upāsaka	A male lay Buddhist who has formally taken refuge and usually undertakes the Five Precepts. The corresponding term for a woman is upāsikā.
Vaipulya	"Extensive" Mahāyāna scriptures. "Slandering the Vaipulya" means rejecting or denigrating those expansive Mahāyāna teachings.
Vairocana Buddha	The cosmic Buddha of all-pervading illumination, especially important in the Flower Adornment Sūtra and East Asian esoteric traditions.
Vajra; vajra body	Vajra means diamond or thunderbolt and symbolizes indestructibility. A "vajra body" is a wish for an incorruptible awakened body, not an ordinary body made of stone.
Vimalakīrti Sūtra	A Mahāyāna scripture centred on the wise layman Vimalakīrti; here it is cited for honest confession and nonconcealment of faults.
Vinaya	The body of monastic discipline: rules, procedures, and ethical training for Buddhist monks and nuns.
Violent ghost of impermanence	A personification of sudden death and uncontrollable change. It is meant to create urgency for practice, not to identify a medically observable being.
Virtuous friend; virtuous advisor	A trustworthy spiritual teacher or companion who encourages ethical conduct, correct understanding, and practice. Also called a spiritual friend.
Virtuous roots	Deeply established wholesome capacities – such as generosity, ethical discipline, patience, faith, and wisdom – that can grow into awakening.
Vulture Peak Assembly	The gathering of Buddhas, bodhisattvas, and disciples associated with Śākyamuni's teachings at Vulture Peak, especially the Lotus Sūtra.
Warmth, Summit, Acceptance, and Supreme Attribute	Four preparatory stages immediately before direct liberating insight in an early scholastic path system. They describe increasing stability and clarity, not physical heat or social rank.
Water Repentance	The three-scroll repentance liturgy attributed to Master Wuda. "Water" recalls the spring that cleansed his affliction and symbolizes the Dharma washing away hatred and karmic obstruction.
Wheel of suffering; ocean or sea of suffering	Images for saṃsāra: repeated birth and death is pictured as a turning wheel or a dangerous ocean that is hard to cross.
Wheel-Turning Monarch	The ideal universal ruler of ancient Indian Buddhist cosmology, said to rule ethically and possess extraordinary signs and treasures. Even this exalted rebirth remains impermanent.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Wisdom of skillful means	Insight that knows not only the truth but also how to present and apply it compassionately for different beings.
Wish-fulfilling powers; mastery of mind and phenomena	Idealized abilities of advanced bodhisattvas to act freely and effectively for beings. They express spiritual freedom, not ordinary wish fulfillment for personal gain.
Yojana	An ancient Indian unit of long distance. Estimates vary; it is often approximated at roughly 6–16 kilometres. In the hell descriptions the huge measurements chiefly signal vast scale.
Yuan Yang and Yao Cuo; the human-faced tumor	Figures in the origin legend. Wuda is said to have been Yuan Yang in a past life, while the tumor embodies Yao Cuo's unresolved grievance after his execution; the story teaches that harm and resentment can persist until acknowledged and cleansed.

Passages and terms that remain unclear

The Fo Guang Shan/Hsi Lai terminology pass resolved many compressed lists, but a few phrases remain edition-specific or genuinely ambiguous:

- "Three Vows" is not enumerated. Several traditional triads have that name, and the surrounding verse does not identify which one is intended.
- "Nine Conditions" may refer to the nine supports for the arising of consciousness, but commentaries on this exact repentance passage do not agree. The glossary therefore explains its practical sense without presenting one disputed list as certain.
- "Eight Defilements," "nine obscurities covering the land," and the "Three Vows" remain broader than a single confidently identifiable list in this edition.
- "When the two practices are perfectly illuminated" does not name the pair. "Our third practice, our third cleansing," "three requests," and three repetitions of refuge are ceremonial wordplay around the third scroll and third ritual session.
- "Its essence does not exceed even a square inch of space" in the imperial preface is syntactically unclear. It may point to the mind or heart as the compact locus of moral transformation, but the English sentence does not establish that securely.
- "We gave rise to [self-]nature without knowing" and "we were deluded to the one nature" are awkward translations. They appear to concern ignorance of the true nature of mind or reality, but their precise contrast is unclear.
- "Truth and worldliness lead away from each other" is understandable as a contrast between liberation and worldly attachment, but the sentence's exact logical connection to the Wuda story is unclear.
- Several apparent editorial errors should be corrected or confirmed before public use: "no part of it remains cleansed" appears to require "no part remains uncleansed"; "contemplation of of impurities" repeats "of"; "Dhama Body" appears to mean "Dharma Body"; "specs of dust" appears to mean "specks of dust"; "responsiblies" appears to mean "responsibilities"; and "Śākyamuṇi" is inconsistent with the edition's usual spelling "Śākyamuni."
- "The Honored One practiced kindness and reverently record this" is grammatically incomplete, and its intended subject and action are unclear.
- The transliterated mantra and dhāraṇī syllables are not ordinary English sentences. In accordance with the English-only scope, this glossary explains their headings and ritual functions but does not translate the syllables.

Sources used for the terminology pass

- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple, Samādhi Water Repentance, Scrolls One, Two, and Three: https://www.hsilai.org/tc/events/eBooks/
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center, Buddhist glossary: https://www.fgsitc.org/glossary/
- Fo Guang Dictionary of Buddhism, English beta: https://foguangdictionary.org/

The glossary remains a reading aid rather than an authorized liturgical commentary. A temple teacher can still supply the intended source note for the few edition-specific phrases listed above.



Part VI • References

Sources, artwork records and editorial limits

Links were checked on 22 August 2026. The guide paraphrases its copyrighted source and uses short labels only where necessary for explanation.

Source liturgy

- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. Liturgy of the Samādhi Water Repentance of Kindness and Compassion: Scroll One. Electronic edition 3.0, 2022. Main source for the companion, page map, quotations, names and ritual structure.
- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. Scroll Two and Scroll Three. Consulted to understand the three-scroll structure and maintain consistent terminology.

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- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. Buddhist Glossary. Primary terminology cross-check.
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Artwork records

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Editorial limits

- Sanskrit names and terms are normalised only where the identification is secure. The source spelling remains the reference for chanting.
- English pronunciation cues are approximations, not International Phonetic Alphabet transcriptions.
- Vietnamese names are a recognition aid only. Tone and regional pronunciation should be learned from a Vietnamese speaker or temple.
- Literal and psychological interpretations of cosmological realms are both identified as recognised approaches. The guide does not claim that all Buddhist traditions interpret them in the same way.
- The traditional Wuda narrative is explained respectfully and distinguished from historical verification.

May the benefit of this work support understanding, compassionate reform and the awakening of all beings.

For further Buddhist terminology

www.fgsitc.org/glossary/